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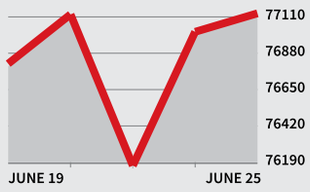

IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	24056.00	+42.90
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.93	+0.17
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.39	+0.07
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	139313.00	-5077
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	216541.00	-15432

WIN-WIN DEAL. **Persistent acquisition** positions both companies for success in next phase of enterprise tech, says Nagarro Co-founder Manas Human **p10**

AVIATION BOOST. **PM Modi** is expected to inaugurate the Bhogapuram airport near Vizag next month **p10**

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

BRANDLINE

The changing Indian kitchen countertop

From induction cooktops to electric pressure cookers and all-in-one robotic and smart cooking appliances, the assortment on kitchen countertops is changing. The shift is led by consumers who want convenience, wellness and personalisation even as household chores transition to becoming gender-neutral. The advent of robotics and AI in home appliances is, in turn, reshaping the strategies of consumer appliance makers. **p6**

LOGISTICS

How NDR built a warehouse empire

India's warehousing sector has transformed dramatically over the past decade, driven by the rollout of GST, rapid growth in e-commerce, rising consumption and the formalisation of supply chains. Among the companies that have capitalised on this shift is the Chennai-based NDR Group, which launched nearly six decades ago with a rice mill and has evolved into one of the country's largest warehousing platforms. **p8**

India eyes discounted Iranian oil after US waiver

COMPLIANCE ISSUES. Some refiners are awaiting guidance on the banking framework

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India is keen to take advantage of the 60-day US sanctions waiver on Iranian oil by resuming imports of discounted crude from Tehran, although some refiners may wait to see if there will be more operational guidance from the US Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) before entering into purchase contracts, sources said.

"The temporary sanctions relief has reopened the possibility of sourcing crude from Iran, which had traditionally been one of India's largest oil suppliers owing to its geographical proximity, lower freight costs and attractive pricing. As long as we are sure that there would be no sanctions against SBI or any other bank that may participate in such transactions, there is no reason why India should not buy from the country," a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

Indian refiners had stopped buying Iranian oil after US sanctions were reimposed in 2019.

SUPPLY RELIEF. On June 22, following the interim peace deal between Iran and the US, OFAC issued a waiver that paused major US sanctions on Iranian oil and petrochemicals till August 21

On June 22, following the interim peace deal between Iran and the US, the OFAC issued a waiver that paused major US sanctions on Iranian oil and petrochemicals till August 21.

ATTRACTIVE OPTION

With sanctions temporarily eased, Iranian crude is expected to be available at a discount, making it an attractive option for Indian refiners looking to diversify supplies and reduce import costs.

However, companies are awaiting greater clarity from the OFAC on the banking channels permitted for settlement under the general licence, the source said.

While there are currently no restrictions on the currencies that may be used for payments, refiners are keen to understand which banks would be authorised to handle transactions and the payment mechanisms they would prefer before proceeding with purchases.

OPERATIONAL ISSUE

"The banking framework is the key operational issue now. Once there is clarity on the banks that can participate and the payment arrangements, refiners can take a commercial call," a source said. Several intermediaries and trading firms have already approached Indian refiners with offers of Iranian crude following the US decision, reflecting expectations that demand from former buyers could revive during the 60-day window.

Before sanctions were tightened, Iran was among India's top three crude suppliers. Its proximity to India's West Coast translated into significantly lower shipping costs compared with supplies from many other parts of the world, while Tehran often offered favourable commercial terms to Indian buyers.

Availability of Iranian crude could also exert competitive pressure on other suppliers to offer more attractive discounts and commercial terms, another source said.

"Even if imports remain limited during the 60-day window, the prospect of Iran re-entering the market could improve the negotiating leverage of Indian refiners in securing cargoes from alternative producers," he added.

HDFC Bank chief reappointment gets legal boost, but RBI unlikely to be swayed

K Ram Kumar
Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

HDFC Bank's board may seek to reappoint Sashidhar Jagdishan as MD & CEO for a third term following a legal review by two external law firms that found no evidence to support the allegations made by former part-time Chairman Atanu Chakraborty in his March 17 resignation letter.

However, legal and banking experts believe the Reserve Bank of India is unlikely to be swayed by a review conducted by law firms appointed by the bank itself. They note that such a report can, at best, form just one component of the central bank's broader "fit and proper" criteria for assessing an individual's suitability to lead a financial institution.

OTHER CRITERIA

The other criteria include integrity and reputation, track record and regulatory compliance, professional competence, conflict of interest, governance and conduct, and financial soundness.

In his resignation letter, Chakraborty said, "Certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over last two years,

Sashidhar Jagdishan

are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics."

In a stock exchange filing on June 26, HDFC Bank said law firms — Wilson Sonsini Goodrich & Rosati, PC and Wadia Ghandy & Co — reviewed thousands of documents and interviewed independent directors and several members of senior management. "The bank and the external law firms repeatedly requested that Chakraborty speak with the firms as part of the legal review, but ultimately the interview with Chakraborty did not occur," the bank said.

However, in an interview with business magazine *Fortune*, Chakraborty said, "I specifically asked the legal firms for the scope and legal basis for such a review. They did not provide me with the details, which is why I did not speak to them."

Having completed an extensive legal review, the law firms concluded that Chakraborty's statement and its implications were not substantiated by the documentary record and witness interviews, per the bank.

Aditya Puri, who was HDFC Bank's chief since inception in 1994, passed the baton to Jagdishan in October 2020.

EXPERT VIEW

Sonam Chandwani, Managing Partner, KS Legal & Associates, said while the outcome of an internal audit or forensic review commissioned by the bank is undoubtedly a relevant piece of information, it is unlikely to be treated as determinative by RBI while considering the reappointment of its CEO.

Banking expert V Viswanathan said the appointment of the law firms appeared to be more to affirm that the then Chairman was "wrong" in citing conflict to his ethics and values.

Legal expert Vijay T Gokhale said there could be reasonable apprehension regarding the impartiality of law firms appointed and remunerated by the bank's management. "The conflict of interest is inherent in such an arrangement... The minutes of the board meeting is not the only repository of evidence of any wrongdoings that may have occurred," he said.

ON HIGH ALERT

TESTING PREPAREDNESS. Special Operations Group personnel conducting a mock drill in Srinagar on Sunday. The Jammu and Kashmir Police have undertaken comprehensive high-altitude operational drills at 18 strategic locations along the twin routes to the cave shrine of Amarnath to assess the preparedness of mountain rescue teams, an official said PTI

Indian IT firms face FY27 guidance cut risk as AI spending and geopolitical uncertainty cloud demand

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Indian IT companies are likely to face a challenging FY27 as GenAI-led deflation, geopolitical uncertainty and shifting enterprise technology spending weigh on demand, with analysts warning that revenue guidance could be cut after Q1FY27.

According to a JP Morgan research report, Indian IT faces an uncertain demand environment as GenAI-led deflation, AI spending and geopolitical headwinds reshape enterprise technology budgets. With spending shifting toward AI tokens and cloud, industry growth and recovery remain uncertain.

"IT services industry has been stuck at 2-3 per cent revenue growth over the last three years. With AI deflation in year 2, we see further headwinds over the next two years. We do not expect large-caps to hit mid-single-digit growth and hover around 3-4 per cent revenue growth," it highlighted.

Q1 revenue growth assumptions for all companies were cut due to delays in deal closures and revenue conversion. Delays in deal ramp-ups and signings were due to continued client indecision from geopolitical uncertainty and sharp AI changes.

UNDER PRESSURE

Moreover, FY27 revenue guidance could come under pressure, with the typical H1 strength unlikely to materialise this year. After Accen-

With spending shifting toward AI tokens and cloud, industry growth and recovery remain uncertain REUTERS

ture lowered its FY27 growth guidance, Indian IT peers may follow suit after Q1 instead of waiting until Q2.

A Nomura report emphasised that the West Asia conflict impact will affect near-term revenues for Indian IT services. The conflict may also affect deal bookings in Q1, with indirect impact likely to continue in Q2FY27 as it is unclear how quickly spending behaviour will normalise, particularly in challenged sectors like automotives.

"We expect AI's projects to start becoming bigger as clients move from POC to live projects. However, a sharp growth revival hinges on macroeconomic improvement, particularly in the US," the report said.

Meanwhile, an Motilal Oswal Financial Services report noted that in Q1, while the AI implementation opportunity will materialise, it may not accrue to traditional vendors like in the past, and a new, platformised AI native vendor template will emerge. "OpenAI's DeployCo (and Anthropic's services company) is the first credible blueprint of the next-gen system integrator. This will not be a winner-takes-all market, and multiple vendors would survive as seen in past cycles, but it will be a painful transition period for the existing book of business," it said.

Similarly, the JP Morgan report said AI remains a headwind, with the industry still in the early stages of an adoption cycle. It expects AI adoption to progress through three phases — deflation, digestion and reflation — with GenAI-led productivity gains weighing on growth before AI services become large enough to offset the drag. The digestion phase could extend beyond FY29, delaying a meaningful recovery.

FPI debt flows hit 15-month high in June, account for 58% of FAR inflows in 2026

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

Foreign portfolio investor (FPI) inflows into government securities (G-Secs) under the fully accessible route (FAR) saw a sharp resurgence in June, making it the best month of the calendar year so far.

FPIs invested around $2.2 billion in June (up to June 25), a substantial rise compared to $0.46 billion in May and weak or negative flows seen earlier in the year, including -$1.25 billion in March and -$0.01 billion in April. This surge has taken total FPI inflows via FAR to $3.81 billion in 2026 so far.

Notably, June accounted for nearly 58 per cent of the total FPI inflows via FAR in 2026, underlining the scale of the turnaround in investor sentiment. The June inflow is also the highest in the past

Monthly FPI investment in debt – FAR *($ million)*

	2026	2025
Jan	1,461	947
Feb	949	1,666
Mar	-1,246	3,340
Apr	-14	-627
May	462	-1,092
Jun	2,199	-1,178
Total	**3,811**	**3,056**

June 2026 data up to June 25 Source: NSDL

15 months, with the last comparable peak seen in March 2025, when FPIs invested $3.34 billion in a single month.

POLICY PUSH

The surge in flows coincided with significant policy measures announced on June 5, including exemption of interest and capital gains tax on FPI investments in G-Secs made on or after April 1.

Additionally, the government expanded the pool of FAR-eligible securities to include longer-duration bonds such as 15-year, 30-year and 40-year tenors, along with sovereign green bonds.

These changes have made the Indian bond market more accessible and attractive to global investors. Market talk also pointed to large institutional participation, with a major foreign investor reportedly deploying about $1 billion into G-Secs of up to 10-year tenor during the month.

Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder & Managing Partner, Rockfort Fincap LLP, observed that the FAR route had seen a sharp pickup after recent policy changes. "These measures have materially improved the post-tax attractiveness of Indian Government securities and have removed a key impediment for long-term foreign investors," he said, adding that future inflows will depend on India's ability to offer competitive risk-adjusted returns.

Echoing a similar sentiment, K Arvind, Head-Treasury, Tamilnad Mercantile Bank, said, "The market has been further opened under FAR, with easier access and tax removal acting as key positives."

Srinivasan added that with elevated US Treasury yields, investment decisions are no longer driven solely by yield arbitrage, but by India's macro stability, policy consistency, market access and post-tax returns, which should support steady FAR inflows over the medium term.

Mumbai port cruises into global tourism map

In the FY27 season, the facility secured eight international cruise voyages

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

Mumbai port is steadily sailing onto the global cruise tourism map as leading international operators show growing interest in making the city a key destination.

In the FY27 cruise season, the port has secured eight international cruise voyages from leading global operators, including Celebrity Cruises, Oceania Cruises, Crystal Cruises, Silversea Cruises and Regent Seven Seas Cruises.

"The participation of luxury and premium cruise lines reflects growing international confidence in Mumbai as a world-class cruise destination," M Angamuthu, Chairperson, Mumbai Port Authority (MbPA), told *businessLine*.

The Red Sea re-routing effect and the restructuring

CHARTING A NEW COURSE. The Mumbai Port Authority is working to further harness the potential of global cruise tourism

of Gulf itineraries could further enhance Mumbai's attractiveness as an Indian Ocean turnaround point for repositioned vessels,

MbPA is working to further harness the potential of global cruise tourism. Its forward agenda includes targeted engagement with international cruise lines to attract repositioned vessels affected by Red Sea re-routing, accelerated completion of the Mumbai Marina and expansion of the M2M network. "We are working in coordination with the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways on the Cruise Bharat Mission milestones and the development of a national cruise terminal network," Angamuthu said.

DOMESTIC CRUISES

Domestic cruise operations have also gained momentum. "The homeporting segment has been the dominant driver of Mumbai port's cruise growth trajectory. The deployment of MV Empress, the flagship vessel of Cordelia Cruises, was instrumental in establishing Mumbai as India's leading cruise gateway," Angamuthu said.

MV Empress operates regular itineraries connecting Mumbai with Goa, Lakshadweep, Kochi and Chennai, promoting coastal tourism and regional economic development.

Buoyed by the success of its domestic cruise operations, Cordelia Cruises plans to induct another vessel into the Indian market.

The induction of *MV Cordelia Sky* (formerly *Norwegian Sky*) from October 2026 marks the next phase of this expansion. *Cordelia Sky* will become the fourth vessel to be homeported at Mumbai, after *Angriya*, *Karnika* (*Jalesh Cruises*) and *Empress* (*Cordelia Cruises*).

In 2025-26, the Mumbai port handled 2.4 lakh passengers with 95 cruise calls in 2025-26.

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Liquor tax bonanza: States see 82% jump in excise revenues

DRAMATIC RISE. UP gets ₹10,000 crore in April-May, Haryana records 82% growth

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Alcohol sales are giving State revenues a dramatic high, with excise duty collections soaring up to 82 per cent in just two months.

Uttar Pradesh topped the charts for total revenue collected, while Haryana clocked the highest growth rate.

State excise duty represents the second-largest component of a State's own tax revenue (SOTR). This tax is levied by State governments on alcoholic liquors intended for human consumption, as well as on certain narcotic substances.

MAXIMUM GROWTH

Monthly key indicators of 10 key States, compiled by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG), showed that Uttar Pradesh earned over ₹10,600 crore in the April-May period of FY27, which is nearly 9 per cent higher than the corresponding period of FY26.

During the same period, Haryana recorded maximum growth of over 82 per cent with absolute numbers reaching over ₹2,300 crore.

Karnataka was second in terms of absolute amount, and Kerala was number two in percentage growth.

MAIN FACTORS

Industry sources attributed this revenue surge to three main factors: A 14 per cent growth in consumption, excise rate hikes by several State governments, and upward revisions in base prices by manufacturers.

Alcohol for human consumption is constitutionally debarred from the Goods and Services Tax (GST). States and Union Territories can fix levies on their own. These include State excise duty on manufacturing, VAT (value added tax) on sales, and cess.

These levies could be *ad valorem* (percentage of the base value) or specific (fixed rupees per litre) and theStates/UTs can change the framework on their own.

For example, Karnataka has become the first State in India to introduce an alcohol-in-beverage-based excise system, while Kerala has proposed reducing the sales tax on liquor with low-alcohol content.

EXCISE RECEIPTS

According to CAG's Publication on State Finances 2024-25, State excise duty is a major component of SOTR, accounting for 13.5 per cent of SOTR of all States in FY25.

In FY25, Uttar Pradesh registered the highest State excise receipts at ₹52,575 crore, followed by Karnataka at ₹35,784 crore, Maharashtra at ₹25,466 crore, Andhra Pradesh at ₹19,882 crore, West Bengal at ₹19,521 crore, Telangana at ₹18,604 crore, Madhya Pradesh at ₹15,201 crore and Rajasthan at ₹15,104 crore.

Significant surge *(April-May/Amount in ₹ crore)*

State	2026-27	2025-26	% Change
Uttar Pradesh	10, 638.64	9,770.69	8.88
Maharashtra	4,522.18	3,850.67	17.43
Kerala	789.64	496.40	59.07
Karnataka	7,086.83	6,371.84	11.22
Haryana	2,343.55	1,283.90	82.53
Andhra Pradesh	3,551.63	2,824.70	25.73
Punjab	2,208.52	1,952.91	13.08
Rajasthan	2,676.86	2,567.46	4.26
Telangana	3,348.55	3,060.16	9.42
Tamil Nadu	1,935.47	1,883.48	2.76

Source:CAG

Mindgrove signs MoU for deploying Vision SoC chip

Rohan Das
Chennai

Mindgrove Technologies, a fabless semiconductor company, has signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) for the first commercial deployment of its Vision SoC chip, tailor-made for CCTV surveillance cameras and other security systems.

Under the agreement, the Chennai-based start-up will supply its indigenously designed chip to Prama India Private Ltd, a video security and surveillance technology company, for its security product portfolio.

Speaking to *businessline*, Shashwath TR, Co-founder and CEO of Mindgrove, said that the agreement currently includes an indicative procurement volume and value without revealing the exact figures.

TRIAL VOLUME

"It is a trial volume which gives us the ability to plan out an initial deployment and use it as a basis for forward demand projections to foundry. As we go into deployment, we will dial in the volumes better," he said.

Vision SoC is Mindgrove's second proprietary chip funded under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology's Design-Linked Incentive scheme. The chip is currently in the late development stages, with prototyping targeted by the end of 2026 and full commercial deployment expected in Q2 or Q3 of 2027.

Shashwath said the Vision SoC chip adds upon the firm's previous secure IoT chips by including features, such as support for higher-resolution image formats, image signal processor and a video codec, while also being much faster with a targeted speed of 1000 MHz.

On the semiconductor supply chain, Shashwath said while foundry availability continues to be uneven, an even bigger bottleneck now lies in packaging.

On memory, the CEO said suppliers are prioritising high-bandwidth memory for AI applications over the types used in IoT devices, which had pushed Mindgrove to explore ways to use alternative memory technologies.

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Pakistan's loss is India's gain: Basmati rice export to Afghanistan likely to surge

EXPLORING OPPORTUNITIES. Traders expected to meet next month to work out the modalities

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Indian and Afghan traders are expected to meet next month to work out modalities for expanding direct trade in basmati rice, following preliminary discussions between officials of the two countries last week under the facilitation of the PHD Chamber of Commerce and Industry.

The initiative comes at a time when Afghanistan is looking to diversify its sourcing of basmati rice.

The country consumes nearly 0.5 million tonnes of basmati annually and has traditionally relied on supplies from Pakistan, aided by the advantage of a shared land border.

ALTERNATIVE CHANNELS

However, the current tensions between Afghanistan and Pakistan have prompted Kabul to explore alternative supply channels, including direct import from India, according to industry sources.

GROWING NUMBERS. India exported 6.52 million tonnes of the aromatic grain in 2025-26, up from 6.07 mt a year earlier

Officials familiar with the discussions said representatives from the Afghan diplomatic mission in New Delhi participated in the meeting and expressed interest in increasing procurement of Indian basmati.

Afghanistan currently sources Indian-origin basmati indirectly through traders in Dubai and Iran, a route that adds to costs.

"Afghan officials believe direct sourcing from India can make supplies more economical and reliable," an industry source, who attended the meeting, said. One option under discussion is delivery of rice through Iran's Bandar Abbas port, subject to agreement between the two governments.

Industry representatives said the proposed July meeting between exporters and importers would focus on issues such as logistics, payment mechanisms and possible barter arrangements.

India imports substantial quantities of dry fruits from Afghanistan, opening up the possibility of structured trade settlements.

KEY CHALLENGE

A key challenge remains the absence of formal diplomatic relations between New Delhi and the Taliban-led administration in Kabul.

"Without an established diplomatic framework, uncertainties will continue to surround any trade arrangement. Exporters also need assurance on payments before committing to larger volumes," the source said, adding that Indian exporters remain cautious about travelling to Afghanistan despite requests from Afghan authorities for a trade delegation.

India's basmati exports to Afghanistan have remained modest over the years. Shipments first began in 2005-06, when about 63 tonnes were exported. After a brief hiatus, exports resumed in 2010-11 and have continued at relatively low levels since then.

The highest export volume was recorded in 2020-21, when India shipped 19,440 tonnes of basmati rice worth ₹108.9 crore. In April 2026, exports stood at 979 tonnes valued at ₹7.74 crore, with average realisation of around ₹79 per kg.

The move assumes significance at a time when India is seeking to expand markets for basmati rice. The country exported 6.52 million tonnes of the aromatic grain in 2025-26, up from 6.07 million tonnes a year earlier.

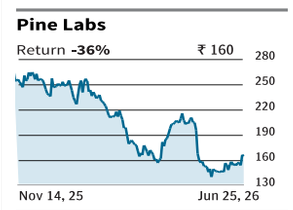
However, export earnings declined to $5.67 billion from $5.94 billion due to lower prices, with average realisation falling to around ₹77 per kg.

Trade sources said a successful arrangement with Afghanistan could help India gain a foothold in a market that has historically been dominated by Pakistani suppliers. While Pakistan exported about 0.8 million tonnes of basmati rice in 2024-25, industry officials estimate that a significant portion of rice shipped to Afghanistan under non-basmati categories also contains blends of aromatic varieties.

TODAY'S PICK.

Pine Labs (₹160): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The stock of Pine Labs, ever since listing in November 2025, has been on a downtrend. But after hitting a low of ₹134.75 towards the end of May, it has been recovering.

While it is too early to call the recent rise as a bullish trend reversal, the breakout of a resistance at ₹155 is a positive sign. We can expect a corrective rally in the near-term, which could potentially take the stock to ₹200 in the coming weeks.

Therefore, traders can consider buying Pine Labs now at ₹160 and place stop-loss at ₹145. When the stock rises to ₹180, raise the stop-loss to ₹165. Tighten the stop-loss further to ₹180 when the scrip hits ₹190. Book profits at ₹200.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading.

milma
Kerala Co-operative Milk Marketing Federation Ltd.
Milma Bhavan, Pattom P.O, Thiruvananthapuram - 695004.
Phone: 0471 2786430, 429, e-mail: qc@milma.com

E-tender invite for Custom Packing of Packaged Drinking Water

MILMA invites E-Tenders from reputed packaged drinking water manufacturing companies having valid FSSAI license and ISO Certification for **"Custom Packing of Packaged Drinking Water"** under our brand name. Interested parties may submit your bids through the e-tender portal on or before **08.07.2026**, **2 pm** in the prescribed Pro-forma mentioned in **"Tenders"** in the website: **www.milma.com**. Mob: **6282751067.** Sd/- **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

TATA mutual fund

NOTICE

Unitholders are hereby informed about the declaration of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal under the Monthly Payout / Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option* of the following scheme. The record date for the same is 01 July, 2026.

Schemes - Plan / Option Name	Gross income distribution cum capital withdrawal amount per unit (Rs.) **	Face value per unit (₹)	NAV (₹) as on 24 Jun, 26
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Direct Plan*	0.82	10.00	99.4132
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Regular Plan*	0.82	10.00	82.4401

***(Monthly Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is not assured & is subject to the availability of distributable surplus).**

Pursuant to payment of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal, the NAV of the scheme would fall to the extent of the payout & statutory levy (if applicable).

Unitholders kindly note that amounts are distributed out of investors capital (i.e., Equalisation Reserve), which is part of sale price of the unit that represents realized gains.

** Payment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to Tax deducted at source (TDS) at applicable rates and other statutory levies if any. Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to availability & adequacy of distributable surplus on the record date.

All unitholders holding units under the above-mentioned option of the scheme as at close of business hours, on the record date shall be eligible for Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal.

Considering the volatile nature of markets, the Trustees reserves the right to restrict the quantum of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal upto the per unit distributable surplus available on the record date in case of fall in the market.

Applicable for units held in non-demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders whose names appear in the Register of Unitholders under the Payout /Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in our records.

Applicable for units held in demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders/Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in Depository Participant(s) records.

Mutual Fund Investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

Govt proposes faster licensing for medical device manufacturing

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare has proposed amendments to the Medical Devices Rules, 2017, to simplify and shorten the timelines for the grant of manufacturing licences for medical devices across different risk categories.

In a gazette notification, the Ministry said the initiative is also aimed at enhancing the ease of doing business, improving regulatory efficiency and facilitating the timely availability of quality medical devices in the country.

FOUR CATEGORIES

Under the Medical Devices Rules, 2017, medical devices are classified into four risk-based categories — Class A, Class B, Class C and Class D — with Class D comprising highest-risk devices.

"The rules prescribe statutory timelines for processing applications for manufacturing licences for each category. The proposed amendments seek to reduce these timelines, thereby enabling faster regulatory approvals, while maintaining the established standards of quality, safety and performance," it said.

For Class B medical devices, which include low to moderate risk devices such as blood pressure monitors, hypodermic needles and pulse oximeters, the timeline for grant of manufacturing licence has been proposed to be reduced from 140 days to 115 days. Similarly, for Class C and Class D medical devices, which include high-risk devices such as cardiac stents, hip and knee implants, and other orthopaedic implants, the timeline for grant of manufacturing licence has been proposed to be reduced from 105 days to 90 days.

The draft amendments also introduce clearly defined timelines for each stage of the licensing process, including scrutiny of applications, audit by notified bodies, verification of compliance and issuance of licences.

The draft notification has been placed in the public domain for comments and suggestions from all stakeholders within 30 days of the publication.

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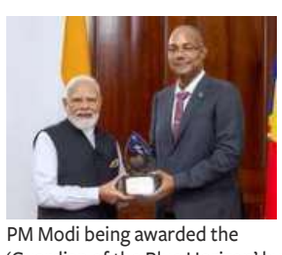
India, Seychelles sign 19 pacts to deepen ties across defence, digital payments, space and healthcare

Press Trust of India
Victoria (Seychelles)

India and Seychelles on Sunday unveiled 19 outcomes following talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Patrick Herminie, expanding cooperation in areas ranging from defence and maritime security to digital payments, space, healthcare, agriculture and education.

The package of outcomes reflects the broadening of New Delhi's engagement with the strategically located Indian Ocean archipelagic nation across security, connectivity, capacity building and development partnership.



PM Modi being awarded the 'Guardian of the Blue Horizon' by Seychelles President Patrick Herminie in Victoria. ANI

According to the Ministry of External Affairs, the outcomes included an extradition treaty, an agreement on cooperation in the peaceful uses of outer space, an agreement to advance UPI-based digital payments in Seychelles, an umbrella line of credit agreement with the Export-Import Bank of India and an agreement for preliminary preparations for a new Seychelles National Hospital.

The two sides also announced the gifting of a fast patrol vessel to Seychelles, the handover of 10 utility vehicles and five Laser Radial class boats to the Seychelles Defence Force, the completion of the refit of PS Zoroaster for the Seychelles Coast Guard and the upgradation of a Dornier aircraft with a glass cockpit.

The countries also signed a pact between the National Payments Corporation of India International Payments and the Central Bank of Seychelles to advance UPI-based digital payments.

An agreement between HLL Lifecare and Seychelles' Health Ministry under the Jan Aushadhi scheme aims to facilitate access to good quality and affordable Indian medicines, the MEA said.

Paradeep Phosphates

Paradeep Phosphates Limited

CIN: L20122OR1981PLC001020
Registered Office: 5th Floor, Orissa State Handloom Weavers' Co-Operative Building, Pandit J N Marg, Bhubaneswar – 751 001
Tel: 0674 666 6100, **E-mail:** cs.ppl@adventz.com,
Website: www.paradeepphosphates.com

NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS

TRANSFER OF EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY TO INVESTOR EDUCATION AND PROTECTION FUND (IEPF) AUTHORITY

Shareholders are hereby informed that pursuant to the provisions of Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (Accounting, Audit, Transfer and Refund) Rules, 2016 ("the Rules") the final dividend for the **Financial Year 2018-19** [declared by Erstwhile **Mangalore Chemicals & Fertilizers Limited**, now merged with **Paradeep Phosphates Limited** (Company) w.e.f. 16.10.2025], which remained unclaimed for a period of seven years will be credited to the IEPF on the due date. The corresponding shares on which dividend was unclaimed for seven consecutive years will also be transferred as per the procedure set out in the Rules.

The Company will not transfer such shares to the IEPF where there is a specific order of Court/tribunal restraining any transfer of such shares or where the shares hypothecated/ pledged under the Depositories Act, 1996.

The Company has dispatched the notices to the shareholders who have not claimed their dividend for seven consecutive years or more. The complete details of the concerned shareholders whose dividends are unclaimed for seven consecutive years and whose shares are due for transfer to IEPF are being uploaded on the Company's website www.paradeepphosphates.com.

Shareholders are requested to claim the **final dividend for the Financial Year 2018-19** and onwards before the same is transferred to the IEPF.

Concerned shareholders holding shares in physical form and whose shares are liable to be transferred to IEPF, may note that the Company would be issuing duplicate share certificate(s) in, lieu of the original held by them for the purpose of transfer of shares to IEPF and upon such issue, the Company shall inform the depository by way of corporate action to convert the duplicate share certificate(s) into DEMAT form and transfer in favour of IEPF. The original share certificate(s) which are registered in the name of original shareholders will stand automatically cancelled and be deemed non-negotiable. Concerned shareholders holding shares in dematerialized form may note that the Company shall inform the depository by way of corporate action for transfer of shares in favour of the DEMAT account of the IEPF.

The shareholders may further note that the details made available by the Company on its website should be regarded and shall be deemed adequate notice in respect of issue of duplicate share certificate(s) by the Company for the purpose of transfer of shares to IEPF.

In case the Company does not receive any communication from the concerned shareholders on or before September 30, 2026 the Company with a view to adhering with the requirements of the Rules, transfer the dividend to the IEPF by the due date.

Please note that no claim shall lie against the Company in respect of unclaimed dividend amount and shares transferred to IEPF. Shareholders may claim the dividend and corresponding shares transferred to IEPF including all benefits accruing on such shares, if any, from the IEPF authorities after following the procedure prescribed in the Rules.

In case of any queries, please contact the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent at the following address:

MUFG Intime India Private Limited
(Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited)
Unit: Paradeep Phosphates Limited
C-101, Embassy 247, L.B.S. Marg,
Vikhroli (West), Mumbai – 400 083.
www.in.mpms.mufg.com
T : +91 22 4918 6000 / +91 8108116767
Email: investor.helpdesk@in.mpms.mufg.com

For Paradeep Phosphates Limited
Sd/-
Sachin Patil
Company Secretary

Place : Bengaluru
Date : June 28, 2026

CHENNAI
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MONDAY - JUNE 29, 2026

Inflection point

With a little support, MSMEs can be a driving force

There cannot perhaps be a better time than the present to take stock of how India's micro, small and medium enterprises are faring. After all, there are 8.77 crore MSMEs employing 38.9 crore people, contributing nearly a third of GDP and half our exports.

Quite apart from the fact that the week starting June 27 is observed as MSME week globally, the world has been through a period of extraordinary flux over the last year or more, starting with the Liberation Day tariffs last April and culminating in the Gulf war. Alongside, developments in AI and electronics are rapidly overhauling production processes, creating opportunities and challenges with respect to skilling, finance and product development. This newspaper organised its annual 'MSME Growth Conclave' in Bengaluru and Coimbatore last week to dive into how MSMEs, and the policies meant for them, are dealing with technological and geopolitical upheavals. At least three broad aspects concerning MSMEs (actually an umbrella term that encompasses enterprises from ₹2.5 crore to ₹500 crore) came up for discussion — access to finance, human resource management and managing the growth path of an enterprise.

To take the last point first, industry leaders rightly observed MSMEs should overcome their reluctance to grow big, which seems to arise from a fear of losing family control. This also means snapping out of the sub-contracting mindset and instead owning a value chain, be it in electric vehicles or dairy. The use of modern equipment and digitised processes can aid expansion and development of new products. To this end, synergies between industrial and educational research must be developed. But to back this ambition, both a skilled workforce as well as a financial ecosystem are pre-requisites. MSMEs struggle to retain talent. It was rightly observed that employees should be able to visualise a career path.

As for finances, MSMEs continue to struggle. According to a recently released Deloitte report, most MSMEs do not have access to formal credit and raise funds from informal sources. While the preference for gold loans seems to be a factor, the banking system must do some serious introspection. Credit can be tailored to cash flows, and working capital requirements met or adjusted to deal with global shocks. Credit guarantee schemes seem to help up to a point. Bankers with intimate knowledge of local conditions must be rewarded for nurturing businesses over time with patient capital. While being wary of NPAs, as in the present times, bankers need to account for circumstantial stress. As for working capital finance, the Trade Receivables electronic Discounting System is not doing very well, despite recent efforts to reform it. The 45-day payment norm is often circumvented. Yet, it is remarkable that MSMEs have shown great resilience — despite Covid, demonetisation and the war-induced shocks since 2022 — to put the economy back on the growth path. Ecosystem support can make a huge difference.

OTHER VOICES.

The Washington Post

Feds controlling ChatGPT access misreads AI threats

Perfect security is a dangerous delusion. That's something close to a gospel truth for cybersecurity experts. This appears not to be the mindset at the highest reaches of the US government, which is trying to regulate away dangers that cannot be regulated away. At the behest of the White House, OpenAI announced that it will allow federal authorities to approve on a case-by-case basis who gets access to GPT-5.6. There is no process for an individual user to get access, only companies. If the Trump administration is buying a little time to harden the government's own systems before the most capable tools are everywhere, this is narrowly defensible. But if the goal is to chase "model safety" in hopes that technology will only be released into the wild once appropriate guardrails are in place, the government badly misjudges the game it's playing. (WASHINGTON DC, JUNE 26)

South China Morning Post

Hong Kong must tackle roots of youth mental health crisis

The mental health problems faced by the young, leading in extreme cases to suicide, are a long-standing issue experienced widely around the world. But they remain a source of deep public concern, requiring constant attention. There were 91 suspected suicides among school pupils in Hong Kong between 2023 and 2025. The figure rose from 28 in 2024 to 31 last year, despite a range of initiatives intended to improve the well-being of students and provide those at risk with support. The reasons for each suicide are complex. But the challenges and pressures faced by young people are well known. Time spent on social media can limit their ability to develop people skills and can expose them to cyberbullying or other harmful content. (HONG KONG, JUNE 28)

It happens only in Indiya

India has stood mercantilism on its head by importing far more than it exports

LINE & LENGTH.

TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN

A lot of highly intelligent people think China is the cat's whiskers. Thus, "Power in international trade disputes in a fundamental sense reflects power over supply, not power over demand, which is something economists have always tried to say."

Paul Krugman, the Nobel winning economist who is a trenchant critic of the Donald Trump government, wrote this in an article a few days ago. He was comparing the US and China.

Trump, he was implying, made the mistake of thinking that bottomless American demand would prevail. But it was China's control of supply that has won out.

Krugman is both right and wrong. China wins only because of its control of the supply of a few rare earths. Much of the rest of what it produces can be, and is, produced quite easily elsewhere.

Yes, it's true that it sells what it produces very cheaply. But that's because of gigantic subsidies and currency manipulation. Economists have researched this to death. Countries have protested. A few have increased import duties steeply. China doesn't care.

When Trump increased tariffs on Chinese goods, he would have succeeded except that he made the same mistake that he made when he attacked Iran earlier this year. He forgot that China controls rare earths just as Iran controls the straits of Hormuz. Every Achilles has a vulnerable heel.

But to conclude from this that it is supply that determines power in international trade is probably wrong. By that logic, Russia should control both China and Europe, which together produce nearly $50 trillion worth of goods and services. It doesn't, because without the demand from China and Europe the Russian economy would collapse entirely while that of the buyers would merely deflate while they diversify their sources of supply.

CHINA'S WEAKNESS

Despite temporary phases of having the upper hand, a single seller is therefore always more vulnerable. The Chinese should bear this in mind while withholding supply. Actually, China knows this. And that's why it's constantly putting out the news that it's invulnerable. But who is it fooling?

Let's not forget that it can't feed itself. Nor is it self-sufficient in energy. In fact, far from it. If tomorrow there were food or energy sanctions against it, together the two would very quickly bring it to its knees.

> **In India equity for labour displaced efficiency for capital. And that** is how we stood mercantilism on its head, because our comparative advantage in labour was wholly neglected

INDIAN MERCANTILISM

But leave Krugman aside and let's return to mercantilism. Where does India stand on it? Believe me, you don't want to know because what India has done is mind-boggling.

In a typical inversion of policies which make neither economic nor political sense, India has stood mercantilism on its head. The core of mercantilism, as enunciated by the Englishman Thomas Mun in the 17th century, is to export as much as you can and import as little as you need. India does the exact opposite.

Two things have been mainly responsible for this cosmic absurdity. One was the political belief that we needed to reverse the colonial economic model of being an exporting country that didn't have any industrial base of its own and the other was the need to stop the colonial maltreatment of labour.

It never occurred to anyone that rapid industrialisation is inconsistent with the mollycoddling of labour. You can't have both. Communist China understood this perfectly, we didn't. Basically, to industrialise massively and quickly, policies have to be pro-capital, not pro-labour.

But in India equity for labour displaced efficiency for capital. And that is how we stood mercantilism on its head, because our comparative advantage in labour was wholly neglected.

So amongst the various counterproductive things we did, we stopped producing for export. But China after 1978 did the exact opposite. It now has a $20 trillion economy. We have a $4 trillion economy. We used to sell to China. Now we buy everything from it.

It is not as if India's first prime minister wasn't told about the negative outcomes of his economic policies after 1957. He was, but he ignored all the warnings.

Can the fallout be fixed? Not unless we prioritise efficiency over equity. Will we do it? Yes but in homeopathic doses, as in the new labour codes.

What does that mean? I think we should replace that 0 in 2047 with 1, to make it 2147.

I mean, look at us. Even after 79 years of Independence we are governed by politicians and *babus* who can't decide what proof is sufficient to establish Indian citizenship. What can we expect of them?

Mahalanobis and the making of a data-driven India

Mahalanobis spent his life building a self-reliant statistical system, which has become stronger with the passage of time

Prasu Jain
Astitva Ranjan Srivastava
Meghal Sharma

Every time we taste a spoonful to judge a whole pot of *dal*, or check a handful of grain to judge an entire sack, we are doing statistics without realising it — reading a small sample to understand a much larger whole. The man who turned that everyday instinct into a science for a nation was Prasanta Chandra Mahalanobis.

As India marks his 133rd birth anniversary on June 29 — celebrated since 2007 as National Statistics Day — his idea feels more relevant than ever. In an age that runs on data and artificial intelligence, the statistician who taught India to find meaning in numbers remains its most modern thinker.

THE PROFESSOR

Mahalanobis began as a physicist, teaching at Presidency College for more than three decades, before a growing fascination with statistics led him to found the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) in 1931 — today an institution of national importance and global repute. He was physicist, statistician and economist at once, and the architect of India's Second Five-Year Plan. As Professor CR. Rao remarked, "His major achievements were in fields in which he had no formal degrees." His genius lay in putting statistics to work.

After the great floods in Bengal and Odisha in the 1920s, his patient study of decades of rainfall showed that the remedy lay in better drainage, not higher embankments — advice that saved the exchequer crores and shaped the projects at Damodar and Hirakud.

His study of community affinities produced the Mahalanobis distance, the D^2 statistic still used worldwide to measure how groups differ. For these achievements the nation honoured him with the Padma Vibhushan in 1968 and a commemorative stamp in 1993.

THE STATISTICIAN-STATESMAN

His most enduring gift was the science of the sample. Asked whether Bengal's jute acreage could be estimated without counting every field, Mahalanobis designed India's first large-scale crop survey and proved that a small, well-planned sample could match a full count at a fraction of the cost.

The result validated the power of sampling and led to the founding of the National Sample Survey (NSS) in 1950. Prof. Harold Hotelling judged that no sampling technique anywhere had matched the accuracy Mahalanobis achieved.

The institutions he built were never meant to stand still. The first NSS round in 1950 used about 240 investigators and 1,800 sample villages; today's rounds deploy thousands of field staff across some 25,000 villages and urban blocks, and surveys once held every five years now run yearly, producing quick monthly and quarterly estimates for a fast-moving economy.

That foundation is doing remarkable work today. The recently released sixth National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6, 2023-24) is itself a child of the sampling revolution he led: instead of counting every household, it reads a carefully drawn sample of nearly seven lakh homes to portray the health of a billion people, carrying his method far beyond economics into health and nutrition. More striking still is a circle now closing.

PIONEER. PC Mahalanobis wove statistics into the work of nation-building

As Chairman of the National Income Committee in 1949, Mahalanobis was among the first to flag a basic weakness — India could not accurately measure what its people earned. More than 75 years on, that gap is being closed: in 2026 the National Statistics Office launched the country's first full-scale National Household Income Survey, covering about 4.5 lakh households across every State and Union Territory and recording earnings directly rather than estimating them from spending.

Alongside it, new annual surveys on household debt and investment, the labour force, the services sector and rural farm households are steadily filling old data gaps, while the base years of key indicators — GDP and the Index of Industrial Production to 2022-23, the Consumer Price Index to 2024 — have been refreshed to mirror today's economy.

IN THE AGE OF AI

Here his vision meets the newest frontier. Artificial intelligence is only as trustworthy as the data beneath it, and India's pursuit of sovereign AI — models, computing power and datasets that are Indian-owned and Indian-governed — depends on having reliable, representative national data of its own.

The statistical system is rising to meet that need. MoSPI's eSankhyiki portal turns vast official data into a searchable, machine-readable resource anyone can query; a Sankhyiki AI Assistant on the ministry's website now answers questions in plain language; and a new Model Context Protocol (MCP) server lets AI tools such as ChatGPT draw directly on authenticated government data to answer everyday questions.

This is exactly what Mahalanobis spent his life building: a self-reliant statistical system, in the service of the nation's own purposes.

A nation, his life reminds us, grows not only by gathering data, but by using it wisely in the service of its people.

Prasu is Deputy Director, Astitva and Meghal are Assistant Directors, MoSPI. Views are personal

BELOW THE LINE

Reshuffle season

As whispers of a Cabinet reshuffle grow louder in the capital, Delhi's political circles say the temple trail is being watched. Ministers believed to be anxious about their future are said to be making the rounds of shrines, temples with every visit being dissected for hidden political meaning rather than spiritual intent. Among the more visible faces has been the multiple controversy-struck Dharmendra Pradhan, who visited the historic Baladevjew Temple in Odisha's Kendrapada district on June 28 and had earlier offered prayers at the Shri Jagannath Temple in New Delhi on June 10. Both visits had public and legitimate pretexts, but that hasn't stopped the capital's rumour mill from linking them to the reshuffle buzz.

The season is proving equally rewarding for astrologers, numerologists and soothsayers, who, according to political gossip, have been making frequent visits to ministers' residences. Whether it's planets, prayers or political arithmetic that ultimately decides Cabinet berths is anyone's guess — but business, at least for the fortune-telling fraternity, is said to be booming.

Hallucinating BOTs

In a recent interaction with users, a wallet company was bragging on how it integrated BOT (a software application programmed to execute automated, repetitive tasks over a network) into the app to analyse users' spending and advice on their investment.

One of the users was complaining that BOTs tend to hallucinate and this can be a big problem in taking investment decision based on BOTs' advice.

The CEO of the wallet company agreed and said it has introduced another BOT to study the hallucination and rectify it. With IT innovations growing rapidly, users must be hoping RBI takes control of the mushrooming wallet business so that their hard-earned money is better protected.

Naidu's social mission

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Chandrababu Naidu has a way of saying things, which even critics find hard to counter. The Naidu government has been actively encouraging families to have more children to address a rapidly declining fertility rate (which has dropped to 1.5).

To help achieve this, the State is offering incentives and is also highlighting the benefits of the traditional Indian joint family system. At a recent pulse polio administration event, Naidu said "such a system should come back" and added that grandparents and other family members instil values in children and provide them emotional support as well. Stressing that child care should not be considered solely the mother's responsibility, he called upon fathers to actively participate in raising children.

Our Bureaus

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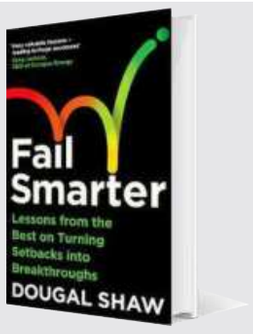
A positive look at failure

Setbacks can help shape successful ventures

BOOK REVIEW.

Sudhirendar Sharma



Title: Fail Smarter
Author: Dougal Shaw
Publisher: Profile/Hachette
Price: ₹499

No individual with ego or self-esteem, whether a leader or a follower, wants to admit failure. Simply put, most are wired not to accept failure. This is largely because the fear of failure is drilled into us right from school days. Consequently, there is an innate tendency to shy away from talking or discussing failures. Sigmund Freud argued that there is a huge stigma around discussing any kind of failure in society. No wonder, politicians are the worst at admitting failures.

The classic works of corporate gurus like Peter Drucker emphasise optimising personal behaviour to achieve individual and organisational peak. They talk of success as the guiding mantra to surge ahead. Nobody wants to appear failed or defeated. Thanks to social media, the fear of failure has heightened, especially among the youth.

DIFFERENT FORMS

Failure has many forms. There are intelligent failures, where one experiments deliberately to learn lessons from them. And then there are basic failures which include mistakes and slips, and complex failures where a mix of factors is at play over which one doesn't have much immediate control. In *Fail Smarter*, business journalist Dougal Shaw draws on conversations with entrepreneurs and business leaders to look at failures in a more positive light. He lists seven lessons from the discussions, and these include: mental strategies to rebuild confidence; recalibrate thinking to address crises; leveraging negative customer reviews; tips to create breakthroughs in failures; and, finding new pathways to success as a team. The overarching message is that failure can be a signpost to success, only if one has grit, agility and ambition to seize the opportunities failure presents.

Fail Smarter is a valuable resource on lessons from failures that could eventually help entrepreneurs succeed in their ventures. It helps understand and appreciate failure better, and harness the creative opportunities that unfold. Despite the rise in number of failures among prospective entrepreneurs, the desire to create start-ups has only increased.

Shaw finds that many business leaders value failures for the lessons they teach, leading to personal growth and resilience. The observations of Josh Bayliss, CEO of Virgin Group, seems apt here: "I wish that I'd known earlier in my career just how important it is to be prepared to fail, because I think that's when you learn the most." Dealing with failure and learning from it make winning entrepreneurs.

Fail Smarter is a veritable meditation on failure, building a positive culture around failure and encouraging people to shift from blame and shame to acceptance and resilience. Shaw captures the personal experiences of a number of leading entrepreneurs in dealing with failure. The most successful leaders focus on what went wrong while building their businesses.

At the Global AI Summit in 2023, the key takeaways that emerged from the fireside chat with delegates from Silicon Valley were: give up the security of the regular pay cheque; and be comfortable with failing. Adopting a more mature attitude to failure can help generate new ideas that make good business sense. *Fail Smarter* enlists many such ideas.

The successful leader must lead by example, both in terms of receiving and delivering feedback on failure.

The setbacks, failures and difficult moments are often the experiences that shape the biggest breakthroughs. So why is there a stigma around openly talking about them? That's exactly what Shaw has explored in his book that combines personal accounts with practical insights on resilience, growth and learning. Failure can be a key character in the story, but it should not be the narrator.

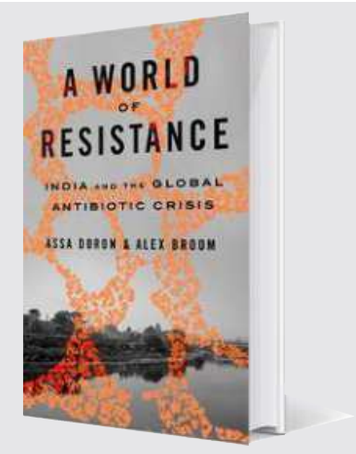
The reviewer is an independent writer, researcher and academic

The cost of over-reliance on antibiotics

The book presents a diverse array of useful perspectives — though India is not a lone contributor or victim as painted

BOOK REVIEW.

Rajeev Jayadevan



Title: A World of Resistance
Authors: Assa Doron and Alex Broom
Publisher: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press
Price: ₹699

The central theme of this work is antimicrobial resistance (AMR), with the authors choosing to specifically highlight India's role within this public health challenge. Before evaluating the book's specific arguments, it is useful to discuss what AMR means. It is a global problem flagged by the World Health Organization where existing treatments are no longer effective against bacterial and other infections, leading to more severe illnesses, prolonged hospital courses, and worse clinical outcomes.

Incidentally, bacteria have always possessed the biological ability to overcome antibiotics. This is a natural part of their evolutionary survival over billions of years, helping them resist lethal chemicals deployed by other organisms in the environment. Thus, contrary to popular perception, it is not a case of bacteria suddenly acquiring an all-new AMR ability after man started using antibiotics.

It is true that antibiotic overuse and environmental contamination create bacterial populations that are relatively more resistant through a process of selection. However, the clichéd narrative that blames individual prescribing patterns obscures the deeper, systemic drivers of AMR globally. These drivers range from large-scale livestock antibiotic use, urban overcrowding, inadequate sanitation, shortcomings in infection prevention strategies, non-availability of diagnostics and limitations in healthcare access, compounded by economic and educational disparities.

Ultimately, the entire world needs to work together to reduce resistance, particularly because the number of new drugs in the pipeline does not match the rising need.

In the first paragraph of their introduction, the authors mention the controversial term New Delhi metallo-beta-lactamase-1 (NDM-1), which was branded as "India's superbug" by the international media in 2008. This created an unfortunate perception that India was exporting dangerous bacteria to the rest of the world, and was therefore an unsafe place to travel to. The terminology drew sharp criticism as scientifically inaccurate, given that resistance genes evolve over billions of years and cannot be attributed to any single geography.

In subsequent sections, the authors discuss the considerable number of tuberculosis patients in India, noting that many suffer from drug-resistant strains. To provide necessary context, tuberculosis remains a monumental global challenge, and drug resistance is an escalating crisis present across several populous and developing nations.

HISTORICAL REFERENCES

Doron and Broom present historical references to advisories regarding antibiotic use in India. However, these patterns must be read in the context of the early post-Independence era, when bacterial infections claimed a vastly larger share of illness and death than they do today. It was the advent of antibiotics, improved sanitation, vaccination and modern aseptic practices that allowed life expectancy to rise quickly beyond the fourth decade. An unintended consequence of this successful historical transition was a lingering cultural and clinical practice: utilising an antibiotic whenever an infection was suspected.

Fuelled by an earnest desire to heal their patients, doctors in developing nations — not just in India — err on the side of overprescribing rather than under-prescribing. This is a multi-faceted process driven by a lack of rapid diagnostic tests that can differentiate between bacterial and viral infections, a mutual reluctance to perform these tests due to cost concerns and patient compliance, a higher community prevalence of bacterial diseases, avoidance of patient dissatisfaction at not receiving a prescription, and a defensive fear of missing a serious bacterial infection when initial symptoms mimic a viral fever. In India, unfortunately, this challenge is compounded by self-medication and the over-the-counter availability of antibiotics without a physician's prescription.

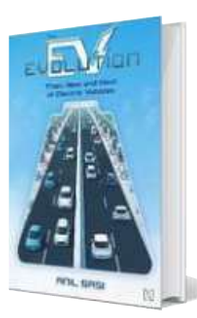
The next portion of the book addresses the rise of India as a hub for generic drug manufacturing, where the authors discuss environmental pollution caused by pharmaceutical effluents. Environmental contamination is indeed a recognised variable in AMR. When industrial waste containing active antibiotic residues enters water bodies, it exposes environmental bacteria to sub-lethal doses of these agents, selectively promoting the growth of resistant organisms. The book notes that environmental resistance occurs as a side effect of lower-cost manufacturing, as well as widespread antibiotic use in agriculture, citing similar studies from China. While it is easy to point fingers at the developing world's manufacturing processes with suboptimal oversight, ironically, wealthy countries are the beneficiaries of this cost-cutting, which incentivises pharmaceutical firms to manufacture generics at the lowest cost possible.

When discussing the veterinary use of antibiotics in India, the book highlights recent measures undertaken to regulate these practices. On a global scale, veterinary and agricultural antibiotic use (which consumes three-quarters of all antibiotics produced) remains the hidden elephant in the room, even as the more frequently discussed individual doctors' prescribing habits and corporate promotional activities grab public attention more readily.

Ultimately, the book, *A World of Resistance*, presents a diverse array of perspectives collected from various stakeholders in India, which will be useful for policymakers in the country to comprehend the multifaceted nature of AMR. Although the authors describe India as the "ground zero of the growing AMR crisis", several processes that drive AMR in India are common to many other nations, including wealthy ones. AMR is an issue where all countries — wealthy or otherwise, big or small, provider or recipient — have a vital role to play.

The reviewer is a Physician and Gastroenterologist, and Convener, Research Cell of IMA Kerala State

NEW READS.



Title: The EV Evolution: Then, Now and Next of Electric Vehicles

Author: Anil Sasi

Publisher: Hachette India

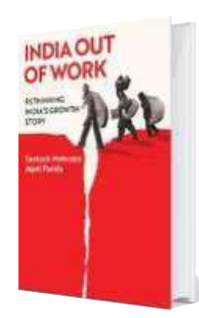
The book traces the full arc of electric mobility — from battery-powered vehicles of the 19th century, to the EV resurgence driven by climate urgency and tech breakthroughs

Title: Take Me to Your Leader: Perspectives on Your First Alien Encounter

Author: Neil Degrasse Tyson

Publisher: Simon & Schuster

If you've wondered why there are so many UFO sightings, or whether aliens might already be among us, Tyson offers an informed perspective that is both factual and fun



Title: India Out of Work: Rethinking India's Growth Story

Authors: Santosh Mehrotra and Jajati Parida

Publisher: Bloomsbury Publishing India Pvt Ltd

The authors expose the systemic barriers preventing millions from achieving economic security and upward mobility

thehindu businessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

June 29, 2006

ADR/GDR rules relaxed for unlisted cos

The Government has announced that unlisted Indian companies would now be allowed to sponsor an issue of American depository receipts (ADRs) or global depository receipts (GDRs) with an overseas depository against the shares held by its shareholders. Under a sponsored ADR/GDR programme, a majority shareholder in a company gets an opportunity to divest a portion of his holding in the overseas market through issuance of ADRs or GDRs.

Derivative deals: RBI says banks must make full disclosure

Banks will have to make full disclosure in their balance sheet on their derivative transactions. Besides profit and loss arising out of derivative transactions, the disclosure should include the nature of the financial instruments used in such transactions. The Reserve Bank of India has come out with draft guidelines on derivative and hedge accounting for banks.

Suzlon gets shareholder nod to raise ₹5,000 cr

Suzlon Energy Ltd, a wind power company, said that its shareholders have cleared a special resolution enabling the firm to raise up to ₹5,000 crore through the issue of a combination of equity and debt-linked instruments.

Short take

Create a safe, supportive environment for doctors

Preetha Reddy

Every Doctors' Day (July 1), it is a privilege to express our gratitude to those who dedicate their lives to healing. But beyond the messages, tributes, and celebrations lies a deeper truth, which is that medicine is built on trust.

India today has more than 13 lakh registered allopathic doctors serving a population of over 1.4 billion people. While national figures continue to improve, healthcare access remains uneven, particularly in rural and underserved regions. For many doctors, each day involves balancing immense demand with limited resources, while remaining steadfast in their commitment to patient care.

The present day is one of a remarkable period of medical progress. Artificial intelligence, genomics, precision medicine, and digital health technologies are expanding what is possible in diagnosis and treatment. Even in an era of extraordinary innovation, patients continue to seek something fundamentally human. They seek reassurance, understanding, and empathy. They look for someone who will listen, explain, and guide them through uncertainty. Technology can strengthen healthcare in countless ways, but it cannot replace the human connection that lies at the heart of healing. Through all this change, trust remains the foundation of healthcare.

Trust encourages patients to speak openly about their concerns. It helps families navigate difficult decisions. It enables meaningful partnerships between caregivers and those they serve. Most importantly, it creates the confidence that allows healthcare systems to function effectively and compassionately. Strengthening that trust is a shared responsibility.

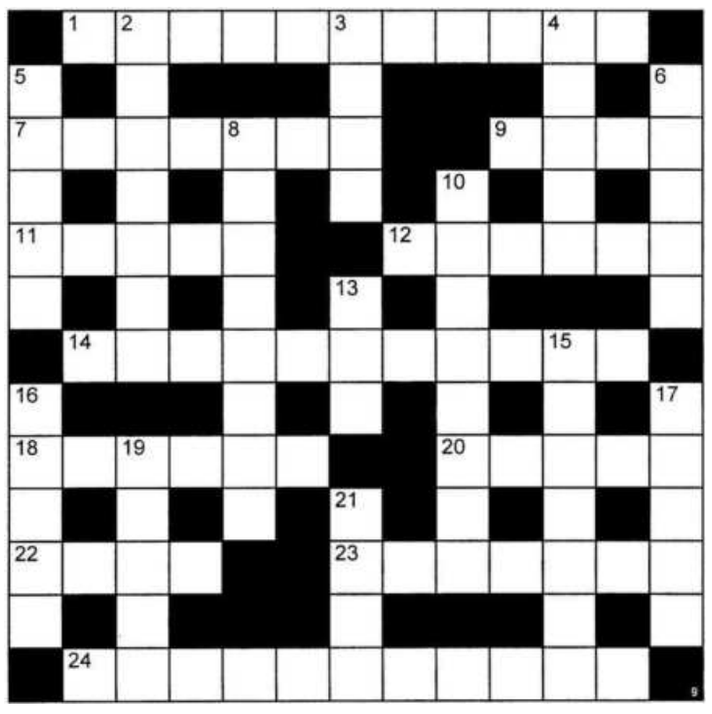
A NATIONAL PRIORITY

Creating safe and supportive environments for healthcare professionals must remain a national priority. Doctors, like all of us, perform at their best when they feel respected, protected, and valued. As India continues to expand healthcare access and build capacity, we must ensure that those who care for others receive the support they need to sustain their own wellbeing and professional growth. It is important to be mindful that future generations will choose medicine only when they see it as a profession that is respected, supported, and valued. The way we treat our doctors today will influence the doctors we have tomorrow.

On this Doctors' Day, let us celebrate not only the achievements of our doctors, but also the values they represent which are compassion, integrity, resilience, and service. By respecting and supporting those who care for us, we strengthen not only our healthcare system but also the very fabric of our society. Trust, nurtured with empathy and sustained through partnership, remains one of the most powerful forces in healing.

The writer is Executive Vice Chairperson, Apollo Hospitals

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2681



EASY

ACROSS
1. Streams flowing into river (11)
7. Need (7)
9. Front of ship (4)
11. Have a stab at (5)
12. Sell from a pack (6)
14. Cave formations growing up (11)
18. One playing to theatre queue (6)
20. Drive one (5)
22. Egg-shaped (4)
23. Vast (7)
24. Broke in speech (11)

DOWN
2. Ask (7)
3. At that time (4)
4. Made a mistake (5)
5. Boasts (5)
6. Dulcet, sugary (5)
8. Was abusive (8)
10. Wild excitement (8)
13. Get old (3)
15. Cost (7)
16. Head of church foundation (5)
17. Lose vital fluid (5)
19. Obstinate mark (5)
21. Brick support (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS
1. Take tube, stir air and these will flow into larger stream (11)
7. Lack twenty-four sheets headed by the Sappers (7)
9. Quietly pull boat to front of vessel (4)
11. Wild shot at those invited failing to include table-top (5)
12. Sell things but soundly work like a cyclist (6)
14. It slams gate perhaps on such as are found in caves (11)
18. Entertainer of queue puts coach on kerb endlessly (6)
20. Drive one to make a pile, including a thousand (5)
22. State follows duck but is before fifty where there's cricket (4)
23. Very large people found in semi-confusion (7)
24. Broke in when cold season didn't begin to put red out (11)

DOWN
2. Polite invitation to be concerned with a search (7)
3. He replaced one in the tin at that time (4)
4. Went off course right amidst stampeding deer (5)
5. Blusters about being first with clothing of poverty (5)
6. In set surroundings we can provide last course (5)
8. Last month Denis was perhaps about to have been rude (8)
10. Maybe lied about one being in spirit of light-headedness (8)
13. To get older, men would begin household set-up (3)
15. Former writers go east – but at what cost! (7)
16. One over brothers rating both being curtailed (5)
17. Apply leeches to the French when in bed (5)
19. Bad mark may be got out of satin (5)
21. It may hold up the wall or stick out at the seaside (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2680

ACROSS 1. Buckles 5. Right 8. Comment 9. Piety 10. Mentioned 12. Eat 13. Cocoa 17. Fit 19. Beekeeper 21. Eject 22. Baggage 24. Steed 25. Winners

DOWN 1. Become 2. Cements 3. Lie 4. Satin 5. Repudiate 6. Geese 7. Trysts 11. Incubated 14. Expiate 15. Offers 16. Orders 18. These 20. Elbow 23. Gun

CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - JUNE 29 - 2026

CANNES LIONS 2026 HIGHLIGHTS

Sipping rosé and networking along La Croisette may sound glamorous, but the French Riviera during the Cannes Lions International Festival of Creativity packs round-the-clock business and plenty of insights

India fails to roar

India had a quiet outing at Cannes Lions 2026, bagging only five Lions (two silver, three bronze) and 24 shortlists — a significant slowdown from 32 Lions (including a Grand Prix and nine golds) last year. Some felt it was due to fewer entries — 676 versus 982 in 2025.

Indian wins included 'The unofficial sound of F1' by Leo Burnett India for Pepsico's Sting (silver lion) and Tata 1mg's 'Sawaal Uthao' by Humour Me (bronze).

Amid heightened scrutiny around entries, there was a dip in submissions globally too.

OpenAI's open pitch

OpenAI made an impressive debut at the 2026 Cannes Lions Festival, pitching ChatGPT as the perfect platform for the ad industry and AI as the new operating model for brands. The OpenAI leadership, notably VP of Global Ads David Dugan and CRO Denise Dresser, talked about how the AI platform was already a strong advertising channel, especially for brands in the travel, retail, health, beauty and financial services. Did the agencies bite? Early days yet, but they certainly chewed on it.

The connection economy

If OpenAI talked about the "intelligence economy" as opposed to the "attention economy", then luxury marketers like Coach's Chief Marketing Officer Joon Silverstein talked about the "connection economy". "The brands that win will be the brands that don't just reach people, but bring people together," he said. He talked about identity and self-expression becoming big, especially among younger consumers and the need for luxury brands to reshape their marketing strategy around this, rather than status.

Creators get more autonomy

At this edition of the festival of creativity, creators grabbed the spotlight and the acknowledgement came that they are now central to brand strategy. Over 250 creators — TikTokers, YouTubers and Instagrammers — descended on the event and were recognised and feted. Some of the sessions explored how independent creators are full-fledged media agencies and the new 'kings and queens' of the ad world.

Watch parties

Conversations at Cannes inevitably turned to football and the ongoing World Cup — after all, the favourite playground of brands. Forecasts suggest there will be an additional $10.5 billion injected into the global ad market during the tournament. With FIFA allowing ads during the hydration breaks as well, and broadcasters thinking creatively about ad placements, the opportunities for brands to score have risen. No surprises that there were plenty of football watch parties on the Riviera.

◉ CULINARY COMMERCE

The changing Indian kitchen countertop

HEALTH AND CONVENIENCE. How AI, air fryers and robotics are replacing frying pans and modernising cooking

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

The rhythmic beeps of air fryers are slowly overtaking the ubiquitous whistles of pressure cookers in Indian households. Smart tech is replacing the greasy *tawa*.

From induction cooktops to electric pressure cookers and all-in-one robotic and smart cooking appliances, the assortment on kitchen countertops is changing.

The shift is led by consumers who want convenience, wellness and personalisation even as household chores transition to becoming gender-neutral. The advent of robotics and AI in home appliances is, in turn, reshaping the strategies of consumer appliance makers.

Anil Dua, COO, Usha International, says there is a clear evolution in how younger consumers approach kitchen appliances today. "While earlier purchase decisions were driven by functionality and durability, today's consumers are looking for solutions that align with their preferences around health and everyday efficiency."

He adds that Usha is witnessing a strong growth in demand for induction cooktops, the iChef range of air fryers, blender heaters, steam ovens, electric pressure cookers, programmable electric kettles and Trienergy+ mixer grinders.

SMART PREP. Kitchen appliance makers see a rising demand for products that are multi-functional and compact

MULTI-FUNCTIONAL FLEX

Appliance makers say Indian consumers are increasingly seeking products that are multi-functional, sleeker, more compact and quieter.

Pooja Baid, Chief Marketing Officer of Versuni India, a manufacturer and distributor of home appliances under the Philips and Preethi brands, points out that young consumers are buying outcomes and experiences alongside appliances.

Inspired by digital content and global cuisines, Gen Z and millennials are seeking versatility and an ability to experiment with food with convenience.

But this does not mean they are giving up their quest for authentic flavours and traditional textures. For instance, the air fryer has become so popular in Indian homes because not only does it reduce oil consumption but also preserves the taste and texture of samosas and kebabs, argues Baid.

"One of our biggest learnings came when we introduced Philips air fryers in India. While the technology offered a healthier alternative to deep frying, consumers kept asking us a simple question: 'Can it make a good samosa?' People were not looking to replace their favourite foods — they wanted a healthier way to enjoy them," she adds.

Moreover, automation alone cannot woo Indian consumers. Perhaps this is why the microwave segment's penetration remains low.

FLAVOURS AND TRENDS

On the rationale behind the launch of the all-in-one OneChef that can air-fry, stir-fry, roast, bake and steam, Baid says, "India is perhaps the world's most passionate biryani market. Biryani preparation involves multiple appliances and several stages, and the recipe changes every few hundred kilometres. Consumers want a simpler way to prepare it at home without compromising authenticity. OneChef was born from that insight."

Ravi Saxena, Founder and CEO, Wonderchef, says the transformation is "structural and generation-led", as consumers no longer want clunky machines hidden away in cabinets but compact appliances that look great on open-kitchen countertops.

Cookware earlier accounted for 70 per cent of Wonderchef's revenues, but today appliances are the main growth driver.

"We have localised smart technology with Chef Magic, our all-in-one kitchen robot, and Chai Magic, the world's first automatic tea maker. We will continue to pioneer the smart appliance layer," he adds.

PREMIUMISATION

Asna Khursheed, General Manager–E-commerce and Marketing, INALSA Home Appliances, says, "Indian consumers are demonstrating a growing willingness to trade up. Appliances in the mid- to premium-price range are growing in demand significantly faster than those at entry-level tier, and we see substantial headroom in variants with superior build, design and smart features."

ZERO-LABOUR HOMES

AI is a major change factor. LG Electronics is championing a 'Zero Labour Homes' concept, where intelligent machines will handle everyday chores.

At CES 2026, it showcased LG CLOiD, an AI-powered home robot that performed household tasks like cooking and laundry, connecting with the LG ThinQ ecosystem.

"LG has extensive expertise in this space. This gives us strong capabilities not only in hardware, but also the software and user experience required to seamlessly integrate robots into daily life," Youngjae Kim, Leader of Robotics Platform Advanced Research Task, LG Electronics, tells *businessline*.

Quick commerce platforms are reflecting this changing demand landscape in kitchen appliances.

"Platforms like Blinkit, Instamart and Zepto, are contributing over a third of our online sales. Buying a kitchen appliance used to be a highly deliberated, multi-weekend family errand. Today, the decision window has shrunk considerably. A consumer decides they want a healthy smoothie or an air-fried dinner, opens an app, and a Wonderchef appliance arrives in 10 to 15 minutes. Urban consumers value instant gratification so highly that they are comfortable making high-ticket durable purchases in a split-second, mobile-first environment," sums up Ravi Saxena of Wonderchef.

Brands and the beautiful game

Beyond the World Cup pitch, how football has inspired marketers

THE CURIOUS MARKETER

HARISH BHAT

The ongoing FIFA football World Cup brought up a charming old memory — me as a young boy in the 1970s, eating ice cream from a football-shaped plastic container. This was popularly called "ball ice-cream" and marketed by Joy Ice Creams. After eating this delicious treat, I would carefully preserve the plastic football, and dream about the legendary Brazilian footballer Pele.

My childhood ball ice-cream indulgence is just one example of hundreds of brands that have been inspired by football — the beautiful game that is watched by around 5 billion people across the world.

FOOTWEAR FOR FOOTBALL

First and foremost are products such as shoes, which are integral to playing the game. Global brands such as Adidas, Puma and Nike are wedded to football, each in their own way.

Take Adidas, for instance. Ever since its founder, Adi Dassler, equipped the German football team with revolutionary lightweight boots featuring screwed-in studs, Adidas has been part of the legend of this game. The Adidas Samba shoe, designed to help footballers train on hard surfaces, has sold over 35 million pairs worldwide. The Puma King and Nike Phantom offer similar stories of football inspiration.

PACKAGE DEAL

Then there are the brands that may not have a direct functional connect with football, but ride the bandwagon smartly. Many use advertising as the key connection — for instance, Apple's celebrated advertisement featuring Lionel Messi, or Samsung's advertisements for its Galaxy 11 phones. Closer home, Tata Motors and Tata Power have both used football beautifully in their advertising.

I am most intrigued by brands that have used packaging innovatively to signal their football connect. This year, Coca-Cola has launched bottles shaped like soccer balls, and adorned with bold geometric patterns. These limited edition bottles have become highly desired keepsakes. Tesco, the global groceries and general merchandise retailer, has wrapped lettuces in a clear packaging with hexagonal prints, making the whole resemble a football. What lovely ideas!

FOOTBALLERS AND CLUBS

Labels promoted by famous footballers constitute yet another stream of brands that ride the fame of this game.

GOAL! As soccer mania rages, brands put their best foot forward BLOOMBERG

Christiano Ronaldo has his famous CR7 brand spanning apparel and shoes, and since expanded to hotels and gymnasiums.

David Beckham has his grooming line House 99, launched in partnership with global beauty brand L'Oreal. Apart from hair- and skin-care, the line interestingly also features beard-care and tattoo-care products, which smartly reflect Beckham's personality. Lionel Messi has entered the world of fashion with The Messi Store, which offers premium garments with a sporty feel.

Then there are the football teams and clubs, which are globally famous brands themselves. Real Madrid, FC Barcelona and Manchester United are perhaps the most popular and have huge following — Real Madrid, for instance, has over 600 million followers on its social media channels. The clubs' branded merchandise, including football jerseys, are hugely sought after and command premium pricing. They also earn significant amounts of money from sponsorship tie-ups with other brands, broadcast and media rights for their games and ticket sales.

In India, too, legendary football teams such as Mohun Bagan, East Bengal and Mohammedan Sporting have traditionally had passionate armies of followers. In more recent times, with the launch of our own India Super League (ISL), teams such as FC Goa, Bengaluru FC and FC Jamshedpur are well on their way to becoming big brands.

ONE GAME, MANY BRANDS

Finally, there are the brands built around football. There is Umbro, the English brand specialising in football and rugby sportswear. Brazil won its first World Cup title wearing Umbro kits, and many other champion teams have worn them too. Stone Island, the Italian brand with a close association with football culture, partnered with New Balance earlier this month to launch a new collection for "on and off the pitch". Then there is CP Company, which is the fashion partner to famous football clubs such as Manchester City. The brand has a huge fan following in some English football sub-cultures.

There are also many other brands of football-inspired streetwear, caps and perfumes.

With the amazing popularity of the beautiful game, I think we will see many more football-inspired brands and collaborations in the future. When more than half the population on our planet is in such deep love with a sport, can marketers be far behind?

Harish Bhat is an avid marketer and bestselling author

◉ BOX OFFICE

Gujarati movie *Laalo*'s word-of-mouth ascent to blockbuster status

Naveen Chandra

Films lead an incredibly chaotic, short life. No other product sees as much intense competition for survival as films do. Every week there's a new film that threatens to draw audiences away from the films released the previous week.

Most films, therefore, front-load their marketing effort with advance bookings, meet-and-greets with the stars, premieres and special screenings to build a big opening weekend at the box office. Generally, they achieve predictable results. A good Friday leading into more tickets sold on Saturday and peaking on Sunday before tapering off during the week for a repeat in the coming week, but with subdued numbers, as theatres give away more screens to newer films.

Consider the daily box-office collections of *Dhurandar 1* and *2*. A similar chart, except that the large number of people who saw the first part created much buzz and drew even more numbers for the sequel, giving it a much higher opening. But the blistering start tapered off within two weeks, as expected.

REVERSING THE SCRIPT

The sleeper hit Gujarati film *Laalo: Krishna Sada Sahaayate*, however, followed a different curve. The story of an autorickshaw driver who encounters Lord Krishna as he tries to manage his miserable life, made on a tight budget of ₹50 lakh, grossed an incredible ₹120 crore at the box office.

The day-wise collection chart shows an inexplicable porcupine-shaped behaviour. For nearly 19 days after its release across 280 screens there wasn't any collection, and it was removed from most screens, crashing to a low of seven screens on day 5, with occupancy less than 10 per cent.

For the following week, the film's director, Ankit Sakhiya, booked 15-16 shows every day and started showing the film to select audiences. Since these were closed audience groups, the occupancy clocked 65-70 per cent during the week. The people who watched it spread great word-of-mouth praise about the film. PVR and other theatres waived the virtual print fee (VPF) that a producer pays theatres to exhibit a film, substantially reducing the cost of distribution.

DIVINE TURNAROUND. *Laalo: Krishna Sada Sahaayate* made ₹120 crore

On day 18, incredibly, the shows picked up to 40, and by day 20 *Laalo* was playing in 100s of theatres. On day 30, it crossed 2,500 shows with a 70 per cent occupancy and clocked ₹13 crore at the box office — a record single-day collection for a Gujarati film.

There's been no comparable example of such a performance by a film, given that it wasn't dubbed or subtitled in any other language. Months later, when the producers dubbed and released the film in Hindi, the tacky production values got them a tepid response.

It catalysed *Deolband 2*, a Marathi adaptation of *Laalo* with a similar storyline, which collected ₹80 crore across more than 500 shows in its fourth week.

Other than possibly Lord Krishna's hand in the film's tremendous success, there are two interesting aspects to it. One is the role of strong word-of-mouth buzz about the film, which gave it more screens as the weeks went by. Second, the poor performance of the films released in the subsequent weeks made survival easier.

Similarly, Imtiaz Ali's new film, *Main Vaapas Aaunga*, opened with a whimper, collecting just ₹1.5 crore on the first day and ending the first week with ₹6 crore, an abysmal low for a Hindi film. In an incredible turnaround, collections surged to ₹15 crore in the second week, reaching ₹30 crore by day 10, following solid word-of-mouth recommendation.

FEAR OF MISSING OUT

When a film becomes widely discussed online, people feel pressure to watch it simply to participate in conversations. Remember how the videos of audiences crying while watching the film *Saiyaara* became so much of a pull that if you hadn't seen the movie then you were out of the social chatter.

The woman sitting next to me at the theatre had left her one-year-old baby at home with her husband to watch *Dhurandhar* on her own. She didn't quite care whether her husband would watch the film or not; she needed to participate in the watercooler chats at work.

Laalo is a low-budget film with low production values. But the universal problems of poverty, debt and relationship issues, the Junagadh landscape, the fight between greed and honesty, and the advice of Lord Krishna touched an emotional chord. As Gujaratis everywhere discussed the film, its awareness spread from city to city, making watching it imperative to be a part of this cultural moment.

The film had travelled beyond its core audience. When a film becomes popular, its popularity itself becomes a marketing tool. In these days of online booking, one doesn't see lines of people outside a theatre for tickets. This euphoria has to be created online. Fans help by watching the movie a few times in the first week and creating a shortage of tickets for others, building excitement for the film.

These days they flood social media with positive messaging, ensuring their loyalty translates into more ticket sales. They also defend the film from negative trolls. As positive word-of-mouth reviews spread, *Main Vaapas Aaunga* drew in the fans of Imtiaz, Diljeet and AR Rahman, and they began filling up the seats.

Ironically, just like its title, the film did manage to make a startling comeback.

Naveen Chandra is the founder and CEO of 91 Film Studios, a Mumbai-based company that produces and distributes regional language feature films

FROM THE LABS.

Longer-lasting zinc battery

Scientists at the Institute of Nano Science and Technology (INST), Mohali, have developed a new chemical additive that could significantly improve the performance of rechargeable zinc-ion batteries — a promising alternative to lithium-ion batteries.

Zinc-ion batteries are attracting attention because they are cheaper, safer and environmentally friendlier than lithium-ion batteries. However, their use has been limited by problems such as corrosion, gas generation and the formation of needle-like structures called dendrites, which can shorten battery life and affect safety.

The INST researchers have developed an additive called BDIM, which is mixed into the battery's electrolyte. The additive forms a protective layer on the zinc surface, preventing unwanted reactions with water and reducing corrosion and dendrite growth.

Laboratory tests showed that the additive helps zinc deposit more evenly during charging and discharging, improving battery stability and extending its operating life.

The research team, led by Dr Ramendra Sundar Dey, also used advanced electrochemical techniques to better understand how zinc behaves inside the battery and how the additive improves performance.

The findings, published in the journal *ACS Electrochemistry*, could help accelerate the development of low-cost zinc-ion batteries for largescale energy storage. Such batteries could be used to store electricity generated from solar and wind projects, provide backup power and support electricity grids.

Researchers said the technology has the potential to make rechargeable batteries safer, longer-lasting and more affordable, helping improve the reliability of renewable energy systems.

Insect's microbial bequest

Researchers at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bengaluru, have uncovered an unusual mechanism by which a beneficial bacterium is passed from a mother insect to its offspring, shedding light on the intimate evolutionary relationship between insects and their microbial partners.

Many insects depend on bacterial endosymbionts — microbes that live inside their bodies and provide essential nutrients.

In the new study, led by Shantanu Shukla of IISc's Department of Developmental Biology and Genetics, the researchers identified a previously unknown route by which such bacteria are transmitted in a scale insect.

The team found that the bacteria first accumulate outside the developing egg. Cells surrounding the egg then undergo dramatic changes in shape, transforming from their normal cuboid form into tube-like extensions. These tubular structures become packed with bacteria, detach from the surrounding tissue and are subsequently incorporated into the developing embryo, effectively acting as vehicles that transport the microbes into the next generation.

The researchers showed that the bacteria play a critical role in insect development by producing essential nutrients, including amino acids and vitamins. Removing the bacteria from embryos resulted in high mortality and severe developmental defects.

The study also revealed how closely the bacterium and its host have co-evolved. The bacterium possesses a highly reduced genome, having lost many genes during its adaptation to life inside the insect.

Intriguingly, some of the functions lost by the bacterium appear to have been compensated for by genes present in the insect's own genome, acquired over an evolutionary period from other bacterial species through horizontal gene transfer.

The findings provide new insights into the evolution of insect-microbe partnerships and the mechanisms by which such relationships are maintained across generations.

◉ OPTICAL COMMUNICATION

Moving satellite data at laser speed

ON A LIGHT BEAM. Bengaluru-based start-up is solving for an emerging bottleneck in space-tech: Limited radio spectrum for downlinks

M Ramesh

Recently a Bengaluru-based start-up, Qosmic, announced a $3.33 million fundraise from a group of investors that included Accel and Prosus. Qosmic is into an interesting technology that promises to make a big difference in a crucial aspect of space-tech — data transfer.

Today, we are seeing an explosion of data from satellites. Modern satellites are remarkably capable machines. Earth observation spacecraft can capture detailed images of vast regions in a single pass. Weather satellites continuously monitor atmospheric conditions. Scientific missions generate tons of measurements from sophisticated instruments. The challenge is in moving the data to where it is needed.

For decades, satellites have largely relied on radio frequency (RF) communications. These systems are reliable and well-understood, but constrained by limited spectrum and finite bandwidth. As satellite sensors become more capable, the communications pipeline increasingly risks becoming clogged.

The solution pursued by companies such as Qosmic is laser-based optical communication. Instead of transmitting information using radio waves, the system uses tightly focused laser beams. The underlying principle is similar to the fibre-optic cables that transformed terrestrial telecommunications, except here light travels through free space rather than glass fibres.

Unlike radio transmissions, laser beams are extremely narrow. A satellite hundreds of kilometres above Earth must point its beam with extraordinary precision at a ground station or another spacecraft. Engineers refer to the process as pointing, acquisition and tracking — the ability to find, lock on to and continuously track a moving target. Qosmic says it has field-tested its optical communications system over a 10-km terrestrial link, demonstrating these capabilities outside laboratory conditions.

QOSMIC RAY. An artist's illustration of laser-based satellite communication

LOOKING BEYOND RF

RF transmission is time-tested, but is hitting a limit. A high-resolution satellite generates one to two terabytes a day, but only gets a few short windows over a ground station; over radio, it can push down only a fraction of that. "By industry estimates, roughly two-thirds of the imagery a satellite captures is overwritten before it is ever downlinked. They have paid to collect data they cannot deliver. That is the problem we solve," says Shreyaans Jain, Co-founder and CEO, Qosmic.

Earth observation is just the first wave — the volume problem is about to become orders of magnitude larger. Jain observes that the entire industry is moving to put not just cameras but also computing in orbit. In the last few months, SpaceX and Nvidia have announced AI computing platforms for what they call 'orbital data centres', with partners including Starcloud, Axiom Space and Planet Labs. "These are not imaging a few terabytes a day — they are building toward gigawatt-scale clusters," Jain says.

At these volumes, radio cannot carry the traffic. The ground link becomes the bottleneck for the orbital economy. "So our market is not narrowly 'Earth observation' — it is the connection between space and the ground itself," says Jain. "India today has almost none of this infrastructure built indigenously, and the demand only grows from here."

USE CASE

The clearest operational example today is the European Space Agency's (ESA) Sentinel satellites, which are behind the Copernicus programme. Without a laser link, a low-orbiting satellite may be forced to wait for nearly 90 minutes of every 100-minute orbit before it comes in view of a ground station to offload its data. The ESA has built a dedicated laser relay, which today moves nearly 40 terabytes a day and has carried more than a petabyte of data.

The agency says even this will prove inadequate when its next generation high data-rate missions come online. "On raw performance, NASA's TBIRD experiment sent data from a small satellite to the ground at 200 gigabits per second, moving more than a terabyte in a single pass under five minutes, which NASA calls more than a thousand times faster than a comparable radio link," Jain points out.

ORBITAL DATA CENTRES

Today, many companies want to put up data centres in space — perhaps encouraged by the continuous supply of free solar energy. Another Bengaluru-based start-up, TakeMe2Space, is into this venture and Qosmic is building optical terminals for TakeMe2Space's MOI satellite constellation.

When you put gigawatts of AI compute in orbit, the data moving between those clusters and Earth is at a scale radio cannot touch. Google's Project Suncatcher demonstrated a single optical transceiver pair running at 1.6 terabits per second in the lab, while a radio downlink tops out at around 100 megabits to a few gigabits, Jain says. Starcloud has filed for a constellation of up to 88,000 compute satellites and envisions clusters in the multi-gigawatt range.

"For that traffic, optical is not a ten times improvement over radio — it is the only way to land the data at all," Jain says.

He makes another telling point: Radio spectrum is crowded, and licensing can take months. Optical communication needs no spectrum licence at all.

ALTERNATIVE VIEW

The user industry has a slightly varied view. Suyash Singh, CEO and Co-founder, GalaxEye, says achieving "pointing accuracy" takes a lot of effort and energy; he would rather use the energy to take more images. He also observes that cloud cover can interfere with optical communication links, making them less reliable than radio-frequency systems under some conditions.

"Optical communications is a great technology for the future," Singh says, but for now GalaxEye is content with the old reliable radio frequency.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
quantum@thehindu.co.in

◉ WOW. Two faces of water

Team Quantum

Water is one of the most familiar substances on Earth. We drink it, bathe in it and sail across it. Yet, after centuries of study, scientists are still scratching their heads over its strange behaviour.

Almost every liquid becomes denser as it cools. Water does too — but only up to about 4°C. Cool it further and it starts expanding, which is why ice floats. Water also stores heat unusually well and behaves oddly under pressure. For decades, scientists have wondered whether these quirks have a common explanation.

Now, researchers say they may have finally found evidence to settle a long-debated idea: Water constantly flips between two microscopic structures — a high-density and a low-density form. The trick was in persuading artificial intelligence to look where humans couldn't.

Researchers at the City University of Hong Kong simulated the movements of thousands of water molecules, generating millions of data points. Instead of telling an AI system which patterns to search for, they let it teach itself — a technique known as unsupervised deep learning. The AI sifted through the mountains of data and picked out signatures that scientists say support the "two-state" model of water.

According to the researchers, AI accomplished in about 18 months what may otherwise have taken years of painstaking analysis.

If the findings hold up, they could help explain why water has puzzled scientists for so long. It would also serve as yet another reminder that even the most ordinary things can hide extraordinary secrets — provided someone knows where, and how to look.

◉ VERTICAL LINE

Why the made-in-India ePlane is unique

M Ramesh

The ePlane Company, a Chennai-based start-up that is building two-passenger air taxis, recently announced that its first prototype was ready and it targeted commercial production of 80 aircraft in 2028.

As an air taxi (or air ambulance), the plane is capable of taking off and landing vertically, without needing a runway. In many ways, the ePlane is unique among the vertical take-off and landing (V-TOL) class of vehicles.

V-TOLs are broadly of two types — multicopters, which, like drones, have vertical rotors; and those with wings. The winged V-TOLs necessarily need vertical rotors for vertical take-off and landing and are, as such, further divided into two categories — those whose vertical rotors tilt during flight to become propellers, and those that don't.

Vertical rotors that tilt after the vehicle has risen — like seen in the Arnold Schwarzenegger-starrer *True Lies* — are cool because after they help the vehicle rise, they tilt to provide thrust for forward movement.

On the flip side, tilting means moving parts; aero engineers frown at moving parts — they are inherently failure-prone.

Well, then — since safety is paramount — V-TOL makers largely resign themselves to winged vehicles with fixed vertical rotors. The problem is that once the aircraft is airborne, the rotors have nothing more to do and are, therefore, dead weight. More weight means the aircraft needs more 'lift' to keep itself airborne. Typically, this 'lift' is obtained from speed — as the aircraft rushes forward, the oncoming air is faster. The air goes above and below the wings; the wings are designed to ensure the air above them move faster than below, creating a pressure difference to provide the lift.

A V-TOL carrying the dead weight of fixed vertical rotors needs more lift, namely longer wings and some take-off speed. Obviously, this can't be done from a rooftop. Also, the vehicle would need to be travelling at a high speed to maintain the lift.

OPTIMISED ROTORS

Winged V-TOL makers have mostly accepted the dead weight (drag) of the vertical rotors as unavoidable. After all, don't our commercial aircraft have landing gear that have no role when the plane is in the air?

So, this is where the ePlane is unique.

Prof Satya Chakravarthy, who teaches aerospace at IIT-Madras and is the brain behind the ePlane, decided to do something about the drag. Around 2018, when he was turning the idea over in his head, he read about an experiment at NASA. The American space agency had explored the concept of an aircraft with thin wings on which sat 10 small propellers each, individually powered by an onboard battery. It discovered that the rotors generated a higher pressure differential above and below the wings as they blew air over them — called 'blown wing effect'.

Chakravarthy was immediately struck by an idea to solve the problem of the rotor dead weight. He told the rotors: "Buddy, no free ride; you have to work."

His idea — and ePlane's uniqueness — was to place the vertical rotors at such a position around the wings that they would also spin and generate lift. The slight difference in the NASA design was that the rotor blew air over the wings; in the ePlane, they "suck" air above and below the wings.

Through 2018 and 2019, Chakravarthy was busy determining the optimum position for each of the four vertical rotors around the wing.

Once that was decided, he found that the idea yielded another advantage — the wingspan could be shrunk to 8 m, making the ePlane "the most compact winged V-TOL in the world".

The vehicle features two sets of wings, each aided by two rotors that are responsible for vertical take-off and landing and help generate more lift during the flight.

Chakravarthy and his team have built a vehicle that can carry a pilot and two passengers, roughly 200 kg, and travel up to 150 km at 160–200 kmph.

After securing patents, the ePlane is now approved in 33 countries, including India, the US, China and Japan, Chakravarthy told *businessline*.

FLYING ICU. The ePlane Company's winged V-TOL air ambulance and (inset) its interiors

◉ MISSION AUTOMATION

How simulation tech can ready robots for the real world

At Taiwan's tech conference Computex, experts explored ways to accelerate the deployment of robo-workers

Rohan Das

As AI advances, its capabilities are spreading beyond the software landscape to the physical world — be it humanoid assistants for everyday tasks or specialised robots for undesirable, dangerous jobs or even entire factories powered by automated robo fleets.

At Computex 2026, Taiwan's annual technology and computing conference, tech leaders working at the intersection of AI, robotics and automation suggested that advanced foundational models, alongside improved data and simulation technology to train, test and deploy robots, are helping fuel real-world automation.

Deepu Tala, VP and GM–Robotics and Edge AI, Nvidia, suggested that the industry has made progress in robotics over the past 10 years, but deployments have been brittle and difficult to scale up.

"But now, with large language models having evolved into vision and vision action models that can understand and act in the physical world, the opportunity is huge," he said.

One of the biggest tailwinds, Tala believed, comes from improved simulation and digital-twin technologies. "Building and testing robots in the real world is slow, expensive and unsafe. Simulation is now good enough to become the primary development environment that can run thousands of experiments simultaneously, faster and cheap. The 'sim-to-real' gap has narrowed significantly," he said.

Physical AI models can now be trained on internet data like LLMs. Tala said he expects simulation and generative AI to help companies gather and use a small amount of human data to create massive amounts of the synthetic data needed to train the models.

The chip giant had, in March, announced a partnership with robotics firm ABB to co-develop simulation technologies for industrial automation. The solution is expected to help manufacturers scale up production, reduce costs by up to 40 per cent and accelerate time-to-market by 50 per cent.

STEELY AIDE. A robot on display at Computex 2026 in Taipei, Taiwan

Craig McDonnell, Managing Director for Industries at ABB Robotics, said at Computex that advances in simulation, alongside improved compute, mean the company can, for example, replicate robot movements in a virtual environment with up to 99 per cent accuracy, allowing it to be digitally optimised before being deployed on factory floors.

"The boom in data centre construction, which was only partially automated due to lower production volumes, is causing increased robotisation demand," he added.

Meanwhile, Nakul Duggal, Group GM–Automotive, Industrial and Embedded IoT and Cloud Computing, Qualcomm, suggested that the intelligence powering physical AI will require more processing at the edge (running AI and machine learning models on local hardware devices) compared to the cloud.

"As robots, cameras, industrial equipment and factories become AI-enabled, they will have to make decisions locally with greater privacy and latency. The edge has to be intelligent," he said.

The writer was in Taipei at the invitation of Synology

CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - JUNE 29 - 2026

GLOBAL BYTES.

SAF projects struggle to take off

Around 200 sustainable aviation fuel (SAF) projects have been announced globally, representing up to 30 million tonnes of production capacity by 2030. However, only around 60 per cent of this capacity is expected to materialise.

Many projects remain at an early stage and risk being delayed or cancelled. At present, as little as 35 per cent of announced capacity is operational or under construction. Actual SAF capacity is estimated to reach around 20 MT by 2030. Hence, nearly one-third of the announced projects are unlikely to take off. Insufficient policy support and the related limited access to funding are part of the root causes.

Jet fuel woes worsen outlook for airlines

Fitch Ratings has revised its 2026 outlook for the global airline sector to 'deteriorating' from 'stable', reflecting profitability pressures from the sharp rise in jet fuel prices, a rising risk of demand destruction driven by higher ticket prices and macroeconomic pressures that create downside risks for the industry. Jet fuel prices have risen from $2.3–2.4 per gallon before the US-Iran conflict to about $3.5 per gallon currently. Fitch is considering a base case scenario and alternative case scenario in 2026 with fuel prices averaging $3.2 and $3.85 per gallon, respectively, up from $2.4 prior to the conflict.

The West Asia conflict continues to affect the sector unevenly. The impact is more severe for carriers with direct exposure to the region or weak financial profiles before the rise in jet fuel costs. Some carriers, particularly in the US, are unhedged and remain vulnerable to rapid price spikes.

"We expect credit metrics to degrade materially in 2026, and the trajectory for rating actions will depend heavily on the duration of the conflict and the pace of any fuel price normalisation. Fitch's base case assumes the Strait of Hormuz will reopen mid-year and crude oil prices will decline gradually. However, confidence in that timing has diminished. Issuers with limited leverage headroom or direct exposure to the conflict region remain vulnerable to negative rating actions, particularly if the conflict extends beyond our base case timeline," Fitch said.

Source: Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways

RE POSTS.

Through the Sagarmala Urban Waterways Transport Ecosystem, over 30 lakh passengers have gained better mobility, more than 1 lakh cargo trucks have been moved efficiently & 2 crore+ litres of fuel have been saved - powering progress through waterways.

IWAI
@IWAI_ShipMin

International travellers can simplify their arrival process by pre-declaring dutiable goods and currency through the ATITHI @ Indian Customs app, ensuring smoother clearance and reduced waiting time at the airport.

Chennai (MAA) Airport
@aaichnairport

With significant investments in National Waterways, modern terminals, enhanced navigation facilities, cargo movement, and river cruise tourism, the Government is unlocking the region's vast inland water transport potential. From the Brahmaputra and Barak rivers to new tourism circuits and cruise terminals, these initiatives are boosting trade, tourism, livelihoods, and seamless connectivity across the Northeast.

Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways
@shipmin_india

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on Jun 11	Rentals as on Jun 25	% change
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,74,000	1,75,000	0.57
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,57,000	1,58,000	0.63
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,77,000	1,79,000	1.12
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,96,000	1,95,000	-0.51
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	2,01,000	2,02,000	0.50
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,17,000	2,18,000	0.46
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,23,000	2,25,000	0.89
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,67,000	1,68,000	0.60
Delhi–Raipur-Delhi	1,64,000	1,65,000	0.61
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,42,000	1,44,000	1.39
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,73,000	1,74,000	0.57
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,02,000	2,03,000	0.49
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	2,00,000	2,01,000	0.50
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,12,000	2,14,000	0.93
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,13,000	2,15,000	0.93
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,45,000	1,44,000	-0.69
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,82,000	2,83,000	0.35
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,84,000	2,85,000	0.35
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,64,000	1,65,000	0.61
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,56,000	1,57,000	0.64
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,47,000	1,46,000	-0.68
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	1,01,000	1,02,000	0.98
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,64,000	1,65,000	0.61
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,55,000	1,56,000	0.64
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,14,000	1,15,000	0.87
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	66,000	68,000	2.94
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	84,000	85,000	1.18
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	66,000	68,000	2.94

Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

ROOM FOR GROWTH

How NDR built a warehouse empire

BRICK BY BRICK. From running a rice mill to boasting a ₹6,650-crore InvIT, the Group's logistics-fuelled dramatic rise

T E Raja Simhan

STORAGE POWER. NDR InvIT manages 22 million sq ft of warehousing and industrial assets countrywide

India's warehousing sector has transformed dramatically over the past decade, driven by the rollout of GST, rapid growth in e-commerce, rising consumption and the formalisation of supply chains. Among the companies that have capitalised on this shift is the Chennai-based NDR Group, which launched nearly six decades ago with a rice mill and has evolved into one of the country's largest warehousing platforms.

The group's development arm, NDR Smart Spaces, is currently constructing around 7 million sq ft of space across the warehousing and industrial park segments. This is part of a 13 million sq ft land and development pipeline scheduled for eventual transfer to the group's infrastructure investment trust (NDR InvIT), valued at ₹6,650 crore, says N Amrutesh Reddy, MD, NDR Warehousing Pvt Ltd.

The rice mills set up in the 1960s by the company's founder, Naidu Dasaradharami Reddy, ran only during the crop seasons, and the storage space remained idle for a significant part of the year. Fertilizer companies began using the space during the off-season, creating an opportunity that eventually developed into a dedicated warehousing business.

Over the years, the company expanded beyond agricultural storage. By the mid-1980s, it was developing warehouses for consumer goods and industrial companies, including Hindustan Lever and Castrol.

During the 1990s, NDR entered bonded warehousing and container freight station (CFS) operations. Reddy says the company established India's first private bonded warehouse and was one of the earliest CFS operators in Chennai.

It was also an early mover in rail-linked logistics. In 2003, it developed a private freight terminal near Delhi-Gurgaon, at a time when there was no formal policy framework for such projects.

The asset, which was later sold to Gateway Distriparks, provided the company with valuable experience in integrated logistics infrastructure. The group's CFS and rail businesses were sold to DP World.

Reddy credits his father and group Chairman, Adikesavulu (son of Dasaradharami), for the growth of Continental Warehousing, the group's integrated multimodal logistics company. Today, its focus is on the free trade warehousing zone (FTWZ) business under NDR Infrastructure Pvt Ltd, he says.

ROLE OF GST

He cites the introduction of GST as the turning point for the country's warehousing industry. In the absence of GST, companies maintained warehouses across multiple States largely for tax optimisation. GST enabled businesses to redesign supply chains around fewer, larger regional distribution centres, he says. This helped reduce inventory and transportation costs while improving operational efficiency.

Anticipating this shift, NDR focused on developing large, compliant warehousing facilities in major consumption hubs. As demand for regional distribution centres increased, the company's warehousing portfolio expanded sharply from around 3 million sq ft in 2016 to more than 21 million sq ft within seven years.

The group's growth received a further boost in 2021 when global asset manager Investcorp invested about ₹300 crore to accelerate the expansion of the platform's logistics infrastructure.

It hit a major milestone in February 2024 with the launch of India's first listed warehousing InvIT, with 17 million sq ft of built warehousing space and around 2 million sq ft under development — cumulatively valued at ₹3,800 crore.

Since then, acquisitions and business expansion have significantly increased the platform's scale. The InvIT now manages around 22 million sq ft of warehousing and industrial assets, serving over 100 customers, and with no single client contributing more than 5 per cent of revenue. The company recently raised around ₹800 crore from institutional investors for more acquisitions.

BUSINESS MODEL

NDR operates primarily as an asset owner and developer. It acquires land, develops warehouses and industrial facilities, leases them to customers and maintains the assets. The operational management is largely handled by third-party logistics providers and occupiers.

Industrial parks account for about 10 per cent of the portfolio, or roughly 2 million sq ft. Under this model, NDR provides land and infrastructure while tenants invest in manufacturing equipment. Customers span sectors such as electronics, engineering and pharmaceuticals.

Looking ahead, Reddy says the company plans to add around 4 million sq ft annually through the InvIT. Expansion is underway in locations such as Coimbatore, Hosur, Pune and Varanasi.

Despite rising competition, NDR remains optimistic about the sector's prospects. A substantial share of India's warehouse stock still does not meet modern standards for approvals, fire safety and infrastructure.

As compliance requirements tighten, organised developers are expected to benefit from the replacement and upgrading of outdated facilities.

The company's biggest challenge remains land acquisition, with large parcels becoming increasingly scarce and expensive. Even so, NDR sees long-term opportunities not only in warehousing and industrial parks but also adjacent infrastructure segments.

It is investing in sustainability initiatives such as rooftop solar power and exploring social infrastructure assets, including education, healthcare and hospitality, through asset-owning platforms, Reddy says.

LOGISTICS DAY

Human link in supply chains

HOISTING THE ECONOMY. The toil of millions of logistics workers keeps supply lines moving 24/7 ISTOCK

RAJESH MENON

Yesterday, June 28, was Logistics Day. Observed since 2019, it acknowledges the vital role played by this network in day-to-day life. It includes everything from the last-mile movement of couriers, e-commerce agents and truck drivers to the vast network of heavy infrastructure like highways and trains hauling immense industrial bulk to ships. This ecosystem also includes warehouses. Ultimately, logistics relies on the relentless, 24/7 toil of millions of workers who keep the world's supply lines moving seamlessly through a robust infrastructure.

India's own ambitions gathered pace when the government launched the landmark National Logistics Policy (NLP) in 2022. It provided a clear, unified direction to a historically fragmented sector by aiming to slash high costs, boost global competitiveness and integrate multimodal networks through digital transformation.

Since the policy's implementation, India's logistics ecosystem has undergone a paradigm shift, validated by its climb to the 38th rank (from 54th in 2014) in the World Bank's Logistics Performance Index. This advancement, driven by infrastructural strides like the PM GatiShakti National Master Plan and the Unified Logistics Interface Platform (ULIP), has optimised port turnaround time and supply chain tracking, boosting the country's manufacturing capabilities.

MULTIMODAL STRENGTHS

The momentum continued during the 2025–26 fiscal period, evidenced by media and government reports of multimodal execution across India. A major cornerstone is the operational growth of Vizhinjam International Seaport, which handled over two million TEUs while securing approvals to develop adjacent multimodal logistics parks (MMLPs). India's major ports collectively handled a record 915.17 million tonnes of cargo in FY2025–26, while average vessel turnaround time plummeted below 50 hours.

On land, the western and eastern dedicated freight corridors became over 96 per cent operational, along 2,741 km of track, accelerating freight speeds and decongesting traditional rail lines. Complementing this is the expansion in the aviation and maritime sectors, marked by trial cargo flights at the new Noida International Airport and inland waterways cargo skyrocketing to over 180 million tonnes, respectively.

Further, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways has revamped the model concession agreement for MMLPs to fast-track public-private partnerships. The MMLP at Jogighopa became fully operational in 2025, with a growing potential for inland trade to Bhutan and Bangladesh. The MMLP at Mappedu, Chennai, embarked on the first phase of operation in 2026; work has started on MMLPs in Bengaluru, Indore and Nagpur.

Simultaneously, highway construction sped up under the Bharatmala Pariyojana, expanding the National Highway network to 1,46,572 km by March 2026, which includes the inauguration of the 213-km Delhi–Dehradun economic corridor. Parallelly, Indian Railways hauled an all-time high of 1,670 million tonnes of freight, reinforced by 35 new Gati Shakti cargo terminals.

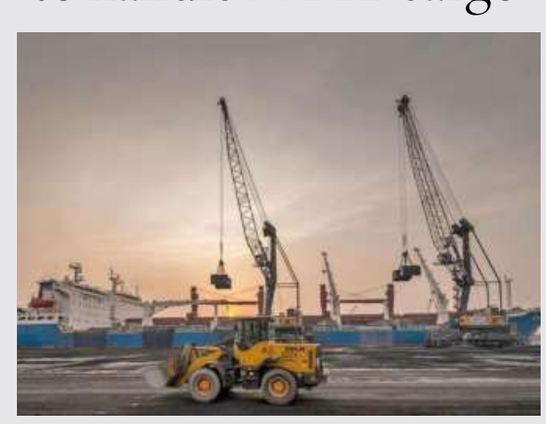
Even as the NLP continues to make an impact across the States, several State-level logistics policies are being chalked up with ambitious targets. An occasion like Logistics Day affords an opportunity to salute the 20-25 million men and women who power the logistics sector, which accounts for 15-20 per cent of GDP, valued around $350 billion and boasting a CAGR above 8 per cent.

The writer is a maritime expert. Views are personal

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

IN PPP MODE

SMP Kolkata gears up to handle 74 MT cargo



EASTERN GATEWAY. Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port

Mithun Dasgupta

Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port in Kolkata targets handling around 74 million tonnes (MT) of cargo in the current financial year, with daily handling of containers increasing nearly one- and-a-half times.

The port, which consists of two dock systems — Kolkata Dock System and Haldia Dock Complex — handled around 71 MT cargo last financial year.

"On the basis of the CAGR in recent years, the way we are growing, we will definitely be able to meet this cargo handling target this fiscal. In the last six months to one year, our capacity for daily handling of containers has increased by a great extent, at almost 1.5 times what we were handling one- and-a-half years ago," Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port Deputy Chairman Samrat Rahi told *businessline*.

"If currently we are handling 2,000 containers daily at Kolkata Dock System, we are very hopeful that we will handle 3,000 containers daily as most of the berths will be on PPP (public-private partnership) mode. Century Ports Ltd has already started operations, and JSW Infrastructure Ltd is also starting operations soon," he added.

Kolkata's iconic Kidderpore Docks' first-ever PPP terminal, developed by Century Ports Ltd, started operations in June.

JSW Infrastructure, which has emerged the successful bidder for the integrated development of the outer container terminal, comprising two berths, and five berths at Netaji Subhas Dock (NSD) at Kolkata Dock System, is likely to commence operations in July.

"All these developments will help increase the number of cranes at Kolkata Dock System, and it will ensure a significant reduction in turnaround time. Moreover, we are planning to have a cement bulk terminal at the Kidderpore Docks. For that, a tender has been floated. A tender has also been floated for a multimodal terminal at the Kidderpore Docks. Together, they will contribute to the augmentation of cargo," Rahi said.

For the Haldia Dock Complex, a major tender has been floated for developing an outer container terminal. "The bidding is in the final phase. This will contribute to the augmentation of cargo at the Haldia Dock as well," Rahi said.

MY FIVE.

SRIKANTH IYER
CEO and Co-founder, HomeLane

Dog walks, intermittent fasting and chess

1. Dog walks: The day starts early with a walk alongside my dog, which helps set a calm and positive tone. Then comes a cup of coffee before heading to the tennis court by 7 am to kickstart the day with energy.
2. Intermittent fasts: I follow an intermittent fasting routine during certain periods of the year, especially when I aim to reset and feel lighter. My approach is a 16:8 cycle, eating between 1 pm and 9 pm, while sticking to water and black coffee during the fasting window.
3. Exercise and reading: Tennis anchors my week. I play for an hour, six days a week, and have recently taken up padel. I enjoy reading business literature, aiming for a book each quarter. My favourites include *Zero to One*, *Uncommon Service*, and *The Hard Thing About Hard Things*.
4. Short walk: Evenings are kept simple and relaxed — an early dinner followed by a short walk. I watch sports on television, and wind down around 10 pm.
5. Chess time: Alongside physical fitness, I focus on mental agility — playing chess for 15–20 minutes daily; it helps stay sharp and enhances strategic thinking.

CAPSULE.

Clean fuel remains elusive

At a time when energy security and affordability have risen to the top of the development agenda, 655 million people globally still lack access to electricity, and two billion use polluting fuels and technologies for cooking, putting their health and well-being at risk, said the World Health Organization. Sub-Saharan Africa bears a disproportionate share of these gaps, with over 560 million living without electricity and 970 million lacking access to clean cooking, it added.

The latest edition of *Tracking SDG 7: The Energy Progress Report*, featuring new 2023 and 2024 data, shows that while most regions are nearing universal access, progress in sub-Saharan Africa has slowed significantly, and the pace of electrification must triple to achieve universal access by 2030.

Despite these challenges, the report highlights encouraging progress in sustainable energy. Renewable energy continued its strong expansion, accounting for over 30 per cent of global electricity consumption; renewable energy generating capacity reached a global record of 544 watts (enough to power a refrigerator) per person. International public financial flows supporting clean energy in developing countries increased slightly to $24.6 billion.

The report will be presented to decision-makers at the High-Level Political Forum on Sustainable Development to be held in New York on July 8, the UN health agency said.

COMING UP.

Self-reliant well-being

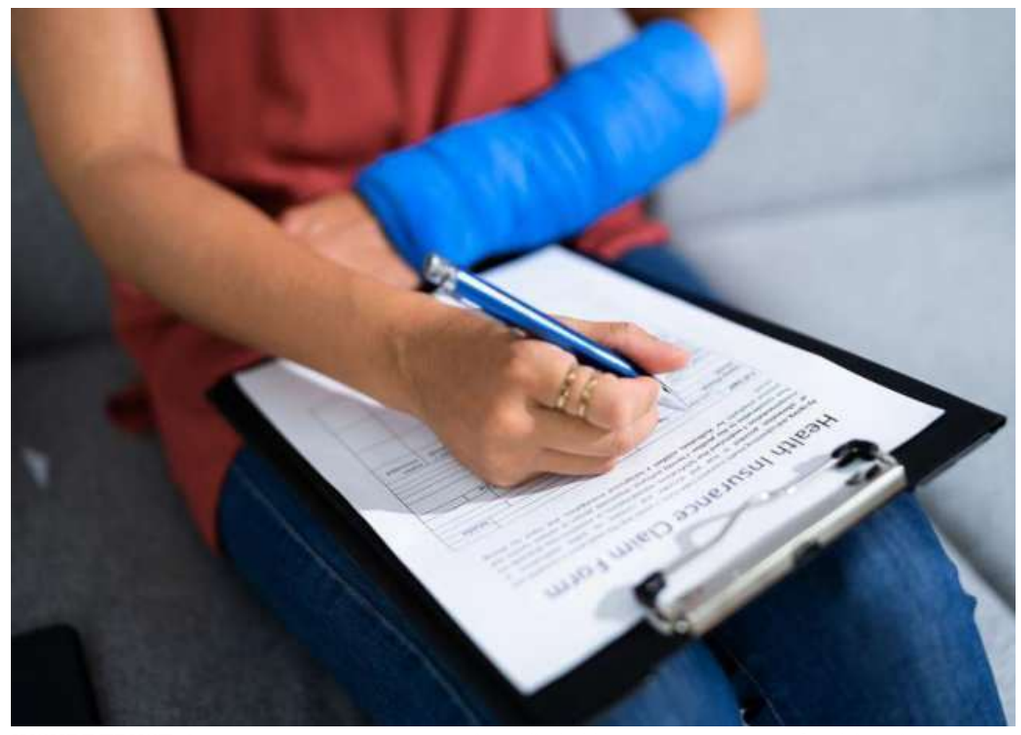
Self-care is the ability of individuals, families and communities to promote and maintain their own health, prevent disease and cope with illness — with or without the support of a health or care worker. The WHO's 'Self-care month' (June 24 to July 24) aims to put "your health in your hands" through the "Test. Track. Thrive" methods.

HEALTH INSURANCE

Cracks in health cover claims

NOT SETTLED. Patient struggles reveal need for easy resolution pathways

PT Jyothi Datta



INSURE TRUST. Consumer groups urge empowering policyholders to contest reasons for claim rejections ISTOCK

About a week ago, a Mumbai-based heart surgeon flagged the case of a senior citizen who was allegedly denied cashless payment for his angiograph, despite paying a health insurance premium of over ₹1 lakh for about three years.

Raising an issue that resonated with several policy holders, Dr Prashant Mishra, cardiac surgeon with Thunga Hospital, posted on a public online platform: "A patient ported his policy in 2023 and fully declared his diabetes during the process (before that he was having (a) Policy since 2021). He has been paying an annual premium of around ₹1.3 lakh. However, when he recently needed cashless treatment, Care Health Insurance denied his claim. Their reason? The patient did not specifically declare that he takes insulin... If a patient is diabetic and has already disclosed the condition, why should it matter whether they treat it with tablets or insulin. In fact patient was on Insulin intermittently only (majority times tablets). So after paying premium for 5 yrs , his claim is rejected (*sic*)."

Mishra told *Pulse* that the 75-year-old person and his wife (68) were retired and their daughter was abroad. The man had come to the hospital after he felt discomfort in his chest and underwent an angiogram. But the cashless insurance facility would not pay for this medical investigation, the doctor alleged.

After paying nearly ₹4 lakh towards medical insurance, he was denied about ₹20,000 cashless treatment, the doctor said. The elderly couple would have to pursue the paperwork for reimbursement, he said, despite having paid for a cashless facility.

"He has to have a bypass (surgery)," Mishra said, noting that in addition to the trauma and risk of surgery, there is financial trauma too. Calling for a middle path in handling these matters, he asks, "When you are going for a surgery, who is thinking about calling a call centre?" He says he has seen other elderly patients, too, in similar situations.

"Maybe IRDA (Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India) needs to look into it," the doctor said, pointing to the pain of patients falling between the cracks trying to get their claims, despite apparently making their health insurance premium payments and disclosing medical conditions.

Responding to the doctor's post, a spokesperson at Care Health Insurance said in a statement, "The cashless request could not be processed based on the records and information available at the time of assessment. The insured has been advised to submit a reimbursement claim, which will be reviewed on priority upon receipt, in accordance with the policy terms and conditions."

Instances of patients struggling to access cashless health insurance come at a time when the Centre is promoting the concept of "cashless everywhere", and hospitals and health insurance companies are engaging with each other to iron out issues between them — through their representatives on the Association of Healthcare Providers of India and the General Insurance Council (representing 32 companies), among others.

Attempts were made by *Pulse* to contact multiple representatives in the insurance industry, but a spokesperson on their behalf indicated they were not available to take the discussion ahead.

'LEVEL PLAYING FIELD'

Bejon Kumar Misra, an IRDAI nominee on the executive committee of the GI Council, said, "If I paid my premium in advance, why should I be made to pay when I get admitted for care?"

A consumer policy expert, Misra said insurance is a business, not charity, and is based on strong fundamentals emerging out of actuarial studies and so on. Pointing to instances of patients being directed to take the reimbursement route to cover their hospital payments, despite having paid health insurance premiums, he said, "There is nothing called reimbursement... Either you outright reject (the claim)... but don't tell me to come back... for reimbursement... Be very clear and give me justifications why you are rejecting my claim."

Further, he said, policyholders need to be empowered to technically rebut the reasons for rejection given by insurance companies. "There should be a neutral body of experts accessible to policyholders to counter the arguments the insurance companies make in terms of rejections," he said, outlining methods to facilitate resolution, audit final settlements and call out claim frauds — without adding to the burden on the policyholder.

"There should be a level playing field," said Misra, calling for experts to handhold policyholders and, in turn, help "build trust in the system, which is today highly opaque".

FROM THE REGULATOR

Canada invests in making health systems climate-resilient

FOR THE PEOPLE. Canada's climate adaptation projects are community-led ISTOCK

Climate change poses a significant and growing risk to health, said Health Canada, adding that more frequent and severe extreme weather events are leading to injuries, loss of life and negative impacts on mental health.

The country recently announced an investment of over $17 million through the Climate Change and Health Capacity Building programme to support 24 community-designed projects that advance knowledge, capacity and innovation in adapting Canada's health sector to climate change. The programme includes climate-resilient and low-carbon health systems (HealthADAPT), and protecting Canadians from extreme heat (HeatADAPT).

Many regions across Canada experience extreme heat events, often referred to as heat waves. Through HeatADAPT, over $13 million has been allocated, including to the University of British Columbia and BC's Provincial Heath Services Authority.

UBC is examining the complex health risks faced by individuals with schizophrenia during extreme heat events and chronic heat exposure. This will help develop critical insights into the roles housing security, indoor environmental quality and social inequities play in vulnerability to heat and other climate change events. BC's Provincial Health Services Authority's work will help strengthen partnerships, research and data expertise to better understand and respond to extreme heat impacts, including heat-related illness and mortality.

The Canadian government has invested more than $6.6 billion in climate change adaptation since 2015. This includes $2.1 billion in commitments since fall 2022 to implement the National Adaptation Strategy and support other adaptation-related activities.

As part of HealthADAPT, nearly $4 million has been allocated to organisations across Canada to support efforts to build climate-resilient and low-carbon health systems.

Source: Health Canada

LENS ON HEALTH

SAFE AND HYDRATED. Nurses prepare to give water and syrup to elderly people at a retirement home in Les Sorinieres, near Nantes, as temperatures rise amid a heatwave affecting a large part of France REUTERS

Hidden hunger: Fixing the micronutrient crisis

Several public programmes have demonstrated how food security can evolve into nutrition security

RAJESH KAPUR

India's nutrition landscape has improved considerably over the past two decades through sustained policies, food security programmes and other targeted interventions. Yet, a quieter crisis persists of micronutrient deficiencies, or hidden hunger.

In other words, there is an inadequate intake of iron, zinc, iodine, folic acid and vitamins, which are essential for growth, immunity, cognitive development and well-being. And for a healthy diet, the quantity and nutrient quality of food are critical.

Left unaddressed, this hidden hunger undermines health, learning, productivity and quality of life. Tackling it is, therefore, a public health necessity and a vital investment in human capital. Well-nourished children learn better, adolescents thrive, women enjoy improved health and adults contribute more productively, strengthening long-term national development.

As India advances towards becoming a developed nation, nutrition assumes even greater importance. The journey towards Viksit Bharat will depend not only on the country's economic growth but also the health and capabilities of its people. Several public nutrition programmes demonstrate how food security can evolve into nutrition security.

By March 2024, fortified rice had achieved universal coverage across government food-based safety net schemes, including the public distribution system (PDS), replacing regular rice with the cereal fortified with iron, folic acid and vitamin B12. Given that rice is a staple for nearly 65 per cent of India's population, this represents one of the world's largest food fortification initiatives. Further, States such as Gujarat and Haryana leveraged fortified wheat flour through social protection and school feeding programmes. In Haryana alone, nearly 17,500 tonnes of fortified *atta* are distributed each month through the PDS, reaching 3.3 million people. These experiences illustrate how existing delivery platforms can be used to address hidden hunger, improve dietary quality and ensure equitable access to micronutrients for vulnerable populations.

CEREAL BOOST. Fortified rice reaches millions of Indians through public distribution system outlets J ALLEN EGENUSE

The next phase must shift from food security to nutrition security — prioritising dietary diversity, supplementation and micronutrient intake, alongside strengthening nutrition literacy to help families make informed choices.

Food fortification offers a practical route to improving nutrient access. India's success with iodised salt shows how simple interventions yield largescale benefits. Fortifying staples like rice, wheat flour, edible oil and milk can further enhance daily nutrition.

Scientific innovation and agriculture also play key roles. Beyond crop yields, the focus now includes nutritional value through nutrition-sensitive agriculture, biofortified crops and improved food systems.

The latest National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6) shows encouraging progress in child nutrition. Instances of stunting, wasting and underweight children have reduced, alongside improved maternal and child health services. Addressing hidden hunger demands a whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach — one that includes policymakers, scientists, industry, health professionals, civil society and communities.

India stands at a pivotal moment. By prioritising nutrient quality, strengthening awareness and leveraging science, among other measures, we can build healthier lives, resilient communities and a nutrition-secure future for all.

The writer is former Additional Secretary, Department of Biotechnology. Views are personal

Honour the calling, rebuild trust in healthcare services

BY INVITATION

KISHORE KUMAR

Every year on July 1, India celebrates National Doctors Day. This year's theme, 'Honour the calling', is a timely reminder that medicine is not merely a profession but also a lifelong commitment to service, sacrifice and human compassion. Behind every consultation, surgery, emergency intervention and diagnosis is a doctor who has spent years training to save lives. Yet, at a time when healthcare has made remarkable advances, trust in doctors faces one of its greatest tests.

With nearly 14 lakh registered doctors, the country's doctor-population ratio is better than the World Health Organization's recommended 1:1,000. However, the numbers alone do not tell the full story. India continues to grapple with unequal access to healthcare, overburdened public systems and a shortage of specialists in rural and semi-urban regions.

At the same time, the demands on doctors have never been greater. A physician today is expected to be a clinician, counsellor, communicator, technologist, administrator and, often, a crisis manager.

Despite this responsibility, public perception is increasingly shaped by isolated incidents rather than the millions of successful patient interactions every day. The reality is that most doctors enter the profession for one reason — to heal. Yet they do so under immense pressure. Studies and data from the Indian Medical Association indicate more than 75 per cent of doctors in India have faced workplace violence, ranging from verbal abuse to physical assault.

Long hours, rising patient load, medico-legal concerns and fear of violence contribute to significant stress and burnout among healthcare professionals. Compounding the challenge is a growing trust deficit. Research suggests many patients search online after visiting a doctor, often seeking validation or clarification about diagnoses and treatment plans. This reflects a communication gap that healthcare must address.

ISTOCK

Healthcare has transformed dramatically over the past two decades. Advances in neonatal care, robotics, fertility treatment, minimally invasive surgery, artificial intelligence and precision medicine have improved outcomes, once unimaginable.

However, as healthcare becomes more specialised and hospital-centric, something valuable has been lost in the process — the enduring relationship between a patient and a trusted family physician. For decades, family doctors formed the backbone of healthcare. They guided families through preventive care, chronic illnesses, pregnancies, childhood illnesses and ageing.

Today, many patients enter the healthcare system only when illness strikes, often bypassing primary care. As a result, healthcare excels at treatment but frequently misses opportunities for prevention. This perhaps explains why social media influencers and quacks are becoming popular — this can be countered through patient educational material from health authorities.

The way forward lies not in assigning blame but rebuilding trust. India must strengthen primary healthcare, invest in family medicine, promote preventive care and ensure a safer working environment for healthcare professionals. Hospitals and providers must also focus on improving communication, transparency and patient engagement.

Medicine is not merely a profession. It is also a promise that deserves our trust, respect and protection.

The writer is President, National Neonatology Forum – Karnataka Chapter; Founder-Chairman, Senior Neonatologist and Paediatrician, Cloudnine Group of Hospitals. Views are personal

CHENNAI
businessline.
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Persistent acquisition positions us for AI transformation era: Nagarro CEO

THE RIGHT PARTNER. Deal positions both companies for success in the next phase of enterprise technology, says Manas Human

bl.interview

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

The proposed acquisition of homegrown tech firm Nagarro by Persistent Systems is one of the biggest bets yet on the future of AI-led technology services by an Indian IT services firm.

Nagarro's Co-founder and CEO Manas Human believes the deal is not only about adding scale, but also about creating a global leader in "AI transformation and engineering" at a time when generative AI is reshaping the IT services industry.

Human explains why Persistent was the right partner, why he believes fears that AI will disrupt IT services are overblown, and how engineering-led firms can emerge stronger in the next phase of enterprise technology.

Edited excerpts:

Could you share how the deal came about? Did Nagarro approach Persistent or was it the other way around?
It's been known in the market for some time that we were looking to take Nagarro private. (The company is listed in Germany).

The AI revolution requires access to capital and resources that may not be readily available in the current listed context. With that background, Persistent reached out to us and we have been in discussions for several months.

Were you in talks with multiple potential partners or was Persistent the only one on the horizon?
We have the responsibility to look at various options, but we have known Persistent for a long time. It is older than us and historically has been a few years ahead of us as a product-engineering company.

However, Nagarro flipped from product engineering into digital transformation. AI transformation is going to be exactly that – enterprise doing digital engineering for enterprises.

So you want a partner with the same DNA as you, and we felt Persistent also had that engineering-led culture. Also, the synergy between the two businesses is incredible.

Some analysts have flagged concerns over Persistent offering 140 per cent premium over the listed share price. Has the digital engineering aspect helped you to get that premium?
We don't feel it's a premium. We feel that the client list that we have is incredible. Despite the software meltdown, the company's fundamentals remain strong.

> We feel that the client list that we have is incredible. Despite the software meltdown, the company's fundamentals remain strong
>
> **MANAS HUMAN**
> Nagarro Co-founder and CEO

It prepared itself for the digital transformation revolution. In 2022, we were the fastest-growing company of any significant size in the world.

Now, we're preparing ourselves very hard for the AI transformation. We hardly lose a couple of our top 200 clients in a year.

You built this company very differently. Is there a concern that the marriage of two different working styles could become an issue?
Both sides are very conscious of culture. Both have an engineering-first culture. Its our hypothesis that there will come this AI wave, a squeeze out, and to be able to be one of the players that can take advantage of the squeeze out, you have to be a certain size and a certain footprint.

Not just a *niche* player, you have to be a player of some heft because at some point, like in the Y2K era, people tend to gravitate towards the safe bets. So, you need to have some scale. No one is going to give core, complex challenging work to an unknown party.

The AI wave is more of a cross-industry wave. It has a lot of commonality. You don't want to be replicating the same motions and investments in different business units.

So, regardless of Persistent, we have already started to simplify our organisation design. We have to find a shared direction where we are going to take the company.

There is also an issue of the business model shifting. We have AI companies getting into IT services, and clients are looking to deploy AI agents instead of outsourcing. How will this merger with a traditional IT services company help you to leverage future potential?
These frontier model companies building services companies is actually a clear endorsement that services companies will be more than relevant. It's also an endorsement that there is revenue and profit in that business.

It will be very challenging for someone to just come in and replace that. Nagarro has easily fended off attacks or competitive moves from partners walking in one of the frontier model companies and trying to hit our largest accounts.

I believe that if you look at the stack of IT spend, digital engineering is just 10-15 per cent. I see the IT sector will diverge.

Productivity improvements on AI will hit both run and build, but while run will not be able to compensate, there can be more work in build.

We can design ourselves around this. If the deal happens, we are going to be able to reinvent ourselves as a company, together.

How will the structure of the new merged entity look?
The deal still has to go through many hurdles. It will take a few quarters before the deal is done and wrapped up.

The most important thing that we want to do is to bring more services to our clients. We will soon have new capabilities, new access and that's the first priority and after that we will see as things go by.

Will you stay on at the helm for some time post the deal? What's next for you?
For me, it's a key priority for this deal to be successful. I'm not saying I will continue as CEO.

What is really important is that the outcome is delivered. So, I remain associated.

The buyer gets the chance to decide at some point but from my perspective, I'm available to make this a success.

Niraj Bajaj charts a less cyclical, more global future for Bajaj Auto

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Niraj Bajaj, Chairman, Bajaj Auto

In his FY2026 letter to shareholders, Chairman Niraj Bajaj has laid out a vision for a less cyclical, more diversified and globally-integrated Bajaj Auto.

Rather than focusing solely on another year of record financial performance, the letter argues that expanding electric mobility, premium motorcycles, exports, vehicle financing and technology will reduce the company's dependence on any single product or market, while powering its next phase of growth.

The confidence to pursue this strategy stems from four consecutive years of record performance.

Bajaj Auto closed FY2026 with standalone revenue of ₹58,732 crore and consolidated revenue of nearly ₹63,000 crore, while maintaining surplus cash of ₹18,137 crore despite strategic investments, capital expenditure and shareholder payouts. This financial strength allows the company to invest simultaneously across multiple businesses rather than relying on a single growth engine.

STRATEGIC VISION

The dominant theme running through the letter is diversification. Instead of relying primarily on domestic motorcycles, Bajaj's strategy distributes future growth across electric mobility, premium motorcycles, commercial vehicles, exports and financial services.

Electric mobility sits at the centre of this vision. The Chairman called for "turbocharging" the Chetak business, improving profitability, strengthening leadership in electric three-wheelers and scaling the Riki e-rickshaw brand. Together, these initiatives aim to create a broad-based electric mobility franchise rather than a narrow, single-product EV strategy.

A similar approach is evident in financial services. Bajaj Auto Credit doubled its assets under management to ₹18,835 crore in FY2026 while delivering a 23 per cent return on equity. The letter positions the financing arm as a strategic enabler — one that supports vehicle sales and deepens customer relationships.

BAJAJ'S ROADMAP

Internationalisation forms the second pillar of Bajaj's roadmap. Exports crossed 2.25 million units during FY2026, with Latin America recording its third consecutive record year and Brazil continuing to scale up production.

The letter reiterated Bajaj Auto's ambition to be a company that "Makes in India for 100-plus countries", reflecting a deliberate effort to diversify growth beyond the domestic market.

The KTM acquisition aligns with this broader strategy. While acknowledging that the turnaround is still "well underway", Bajaj framed the Austrian motorcycle maker as a long-term strategic investment that strengthens Bajaj Auto's global premium motorcycle portfolio and international footprint, rather than simply serving as a financial rescue.

The rare-earth magnet disruption during FY2026 reinforced the importance of engineering capability and supply-chain resilience. Bajaj Auto Technology redesigned electric motors around alternate materials and sourcing arrangements to restore production. The letter also highlighted capacity expansion, product innovation and Project Velocity as key initiatives aimed at enhancing execution and organisational agility.

The letter also acknowledged that the domestic motorcycle market share declined from 16.6 per cent to 15.6 per cent during FY2026 as competition intensified in the entry and mid-commuter segments. Significantly, strengthening competitiveness in the 125cc-plus motorcycle segment is the first priority in Bajaj's FY2027 agenda, signalling that the management sees premiumisation as the path to regaining momentum.

Air India and Delhi airport begin transshipment trials

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Air India and Delhi airport are trialling cargo transshipment under a new rule that waives the requirement of re-screening during transit.

The rule, once implemented, will help Indian airlines increase loads and tap into new markets.

It is also a policy enabler for Indian airports, which compete with regional hubs for traffic.

Currently, all goods that are transshipped via Indian airports need to be x-rayed (security screened) during transit.

This rule applies to domestic cargo as well if there is a change in aircraft. This adds to costs and ground time, making Indian airlines and airports less competitive in comparison to regional players.

Last July, the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) modified the rule to enable transshipment of goods without re-screening at the transit point, subject to certain conditions.

Trials for cargo transshipment have started with Air India carrying cargo from South India to Europe via Delhi

A source said trials for cargo transshipment had started with Air India carrying cargo from South India to Europe via Delhi.

Air India and Delhi International Airport Ltd didn't respond to a query.

The BCAS rule requires the creation of transfer cargo security hold area at airports where transfer cargo and mail shall be stored and protected from unauthorised interference through security control measures.

FASTER CLEARANCE

Delhi airport has a dedicated area on the airside to process transshipment cargo. Established in 2019, the facility will need to be vetted by the BCAS and certified as a regulated agent to ensure secure handling of cargo.

"It is a step in the right direction and will encourage freighter operations in the country," said Vijay Kumar, CEO, Express Industry Council of India.

"Like all major hubs, we must enable tail-to-tail transfers (transfer of cargo from one aircraft to another) for all flights on the ramp. High speed cargo screening machines must be introduced at airports for expedited clearances," he said.

Air cargo traffic handled at Indian airports increased by 6.2 per cent on a year-on-year basis to 3.96 million tonnes in FY2026.

Delhi continues to be the largest cargo hub, while Chennai emerged as the fastest growing airport, recording 11.7 per cent growth in volumes.

Transfer or transit cargo accounts for less than 10 per cent of India's overall air cargo volume, and the policy relaxation is expected to help the industry as India aspires to handle 10 million tonnes of air cargo by 2030.

PM Modi to inaugurate AP's first greenfield airport in July

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The Bhogapuram International Airport, being developed by the GMR Group near Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh, is all set to be inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

According to a senior official, the Prime Minister is expected to inaugurate the first greenfield airport in Andhra Pradesh in the third week of July. A few probable dates have been suggested to the Prime Minister's Office for that week, it is learnt.

Meanwhile, the other modalities for the functioning of the airport are being worked out.

A recent order by the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) permitted the Bhogapuram airport to levy a user development fee (UDF) of ₹835 on departing domestic passengers and ₹355 on arriving domestic passengers. International passengers will pay ₹1,255 on departure and ₹545 on arrival.

While the UDF is on the higher side compared to other airports in the country, the official said the comparison is 'improper' because Bhogapuram is a greenfield airport, while others have been in operation for many years.

SET FOR TAKE-OFF. In January, an Air India flight from Delhi landed successfully in Bhogapuram as part of the trial run

CONNECTIVITY PUSH

As the airport is located about 50 km from Visakhapatnam city, the government is hastening the construction of connecting roads to facilitate ease of logistics for travellers and cargo.

"As the operations are expected to commence within a couple of weeks after the formal inauguration, ease of travel will be ensured," the official said.

In January, an Air India flight from Delhi landed successfully at the Bhogapuram airport as part of its maiden trial run.

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New Transport Ministry cybersecurity guidelines may increase connected vehicles' costs by ₹10,000-15,000

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The clock has started ticking for India's automotive industry, and for buyers of its next generation of connected vehicles.

From software-rich vehicles such as the Tata Harrier EV, Mahindra XEV 9e, BE 6, Tata Curvv.ev and Hyundai Creta Electric to connected buses, trucks and smart tractors, the next generation of vehicles will have to be built with cybersecurity at their core rather than treating it as another software feature.

Industry estimates suggest meeting the new requirements could add ₹10,000-15,000 to the cost of highly-connected vehicles through investments in secure electronics, software validation and long-term cybersecurity support.

In return, buyers stand to gain stronger protection against cyber threats, safer over-the-air (OTA) software updates, better protection of vehicle data and faster software fixes throughout a vehicle's life, while automakers and component suppliers will have to redesign everything from electronic architecture to software development and long-term lifecycle support.

Driving this shift is a draft notification issued by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) on June 22, proposing the insertion of Rules 125-T and 125-U into the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989.

The proposal would make compliance with AIS-189 for Cyber Security Management Systems (CSMS) and AIS-190 for Software Update Management Systems (SUMS) mandatory for vehicle type approval, with implementation beginning on October 1, 2026, for new Level 3 automated vehicles before expanding in phases to connected passenger vehicles, commercial vehicles, tractors and construction equipment through October 2029, aligning India with cybersecurity regulations already in force across the European Union, Japan and South Korea.

BUSINESSLINE

SOFTWARE UPDATES

The regulation opens opportunities for semiconductor companies, embedded software developers, cybersecurity firms, engineering service providers and automotive testing agencies as software becomes a larger part of the automotive value chain. For buyers, most of these changes will remain invisible, but their benefits may be felt every day. Imagine buying a connected Harrier EV or XEV 9e in 2028.

Over the next decade, the vehicle could receive dozens of software updates to improve battery performance, enhance driver-assistance systems, fix bugs or strengthen security.

Under the proposed framework, those updates would have to be authenticated, recorded and designed to fail safely if something goes wrong, reducing the risk of corrupted or unauthorised software being installed.

MoRTH is effectively saying that software must now be engineered with the same discipline as brakes or airbags.

While the first deadline applies only to new Level 3 automated vehicles, the engineering work starts much earlier. A new vehicle typically spends 18 to 30 months in development before reaching a showroom, and by then much of its electronic architecture, including software, electronic control units and semiconductor choices, has already been frozen.

AVOIDING DELAYS

Manufacturers planning launches over the next few years will therefore have to integrate cybersecurity into vehicle development today if they want to avoid delays in type approval.

The additional investment will inevitably raise development costs, although the extent to which that translates into higher sticker prices will depend on how much manufacturers absorb in a competitive market.

Much of the spending will go towards secure electronics, software engineering, cybersecurity testing, certification and lifecycle support.